

Hindi, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Hindi one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Devanagari letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read नमस्ते and learn that it means “I bow to you” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already knows Devanagari simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Hindi’s depth comes from a double inheritance. Much of its core vocabulary is **Sanskrit** — नमस्ते and धन्यवाद sit on ancient roots (*nam*, “to bow”; *dhanya*, “worthy”). But centuries of Persian as the language of courts layered on a second vocabulary, Persian and (through it) Arabic — so “thanks” is also शुक्रिया (*shukriyā*, the same Semitic root as Arabic *shukran*), and “farewell” is अलविदा (*alvidā*, “the farewell,” carrying the Arabic article *al-*). The book keeps both streams in view.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Hindi out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is

gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The Hindi greetings — and, taught through them, how to read Devanagari and Hindi’s double inheritance (Sanskrit and Perso-Arabic). Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once.

1.1 नमस्ते (*namaste*) — “I bow to you”

The letters in this word

Hindi reads **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” न na, म ma, स sa, त ta. A vowel sign changes the vowel: े makes “e” (ते = te). A *halant* (the stroke under स्) *removes* the vowel, and the bare consonant leans onto the next as a **conjunct**: स् + ते → स्ते. Read left to right: न·म·स्ते → *namaste*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्ते = नमः (*namaḥ*, “a bow, reverence,” from Sanskrit root नम् *nam*, “to bow”) + ते (*te*, “to you”) = literally “**I bow to you.**” The root *nam* also builds *namaskār* (next), and *namaste* is borrowed whole into English.

Why it’s said this way

A real gesture, not a bland “hi”: said with palms pressed together, in respect. Works as both hello and goodbye, any time, polite without being stiff.

1.2 नमस्कार (*namaskār*) — the more formal bow

The letters in this word

New: क ka, र ra, and the sign ा for long “ā” (का = kā). You already read नमस् (*namas*). न·म·स्·का·र → *namaskār*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्कार = नमः (*namah*, “bow,” root *nam*) + कार (*kāra*, “the making/doing of,” from Sanskrit कृ *kr*, “to do”). Literally “the making of a bow.” That piece *-kāra* (“the act of _____”) recurs across Sanskrit vocabulary.

A notch more **formal** than *namaste* — ceremonial, or for elders and writing.

1.3 धन्यवाद (*dhanyavād*) — “thank you,” the Sanskrit way

The letters in this word

New: ध dha, य ya, व va, द da, and a new conjunct न् + य → न्य (“nya”). ध·न्·य·वा·द → *dhanyavād*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

धन्यवाद = धन्य (*dhanya*, “worthy, blessed,” from धन *dhana*, “wealth”) + वाद (*vāda*, “a saying,” from Sanskrit वद् *vad*, “to speak”). Literally “an utterance of [you are] worthy” — a formal, literary “thanks.”

Why it’s said this way

The **formal, Sanskritic** “thank you” — written, official, respectful. For everyday thanks Hindi often reaches for a lighter Persian word, शुक्रिया — next — and holding the two together is the best window into Hindi.

1.4 शुक्रिया (*shukriyā*) — Hindi's other heritage

The letters in this word

New: श sha, and the sign ि for “i” (written *before* the consonant, read *after*). With a conjunct क् + र → क्र (“kra”): शु·क्·रि·या → *shukriyā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

शुक्रिया is *not* Sanskrit. It came through Persian from **Arabic** *shukr* (“gratitude”), root **sh-k-r** — the *same word* as Arabic *shukran*. Two unrelated languages, one Semitic root for thanks.

Why it's said this way

Centuries of Persian as the court language poured Persian and Arabic words into everyday Hindi/Urdu, so Hindi carries **two vocabularies**: Sanskrit (*dhanyavād*, *namaste*) and Perso-Arabic (*shukriyā*, *alvidā*). Often the Sanskrit word is formal and the Persian one everyday. *shukriyā* is the casual, everyday “thanks.”

1.5 अलविदा (*alvidā*) — “the farewell”

The letters in this word

New: the independent vowel अ (“a,” for a word that *starts* with a vowel) and ल la. अ·ल·वि·दा → *alvidā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

अलविदा came through Persian from **Arabic** *al-widā'* (“the farewell”), root **w-d-'**. At the front is अल — the Arabic article **al-**, “the,” the same one riding inside English *algebra* and *alcohol*. So *alvidā* is literally “the farewell.”

Why it's said this way

Carries **finality** — the goodbye for a long or final parting. For casual “bye,” Hindi uses *namaste* again, or *phir milenge* (“we’ll meet again”).

Next chapter: *āp* vs. *tum* (formal and informal “you”), and introducing yourself.

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

मेरा नाम मीरा है। (*merā nām Mīra hai* — “My name is Mira.”)
आपका नाम क्या है? (*āpkā nām kyā hai* — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and its root, then assembled.

2.1 नाम (*nām*) — “name,” a word older than Europe

The letters in this word

Three letters, left to right: न (*na*), ा the long-ā *mātrā* (ना = *nā*), म (*ma*).
Read ना·म → *nām*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नाम (*nām*) ← Sanskrit नामन् (*nāman*), from Proto-Indo-European **h₃nómn*. — the *same* ancient root as English **name**, Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**, **nominate**), and Greek *onoma*. So Hindi *nām* and English *name* are cousins from before either language existed — one of the clearest bridges between the Indian and European branches of the same family.

2.2 मेरा (*merā*) — “my”

The letters in this word

म (*ma*) + े (the *e-mātrā*) → मे (*me*); then र (*ra*) + ा (long *ā*) → रा (*rā*).
Read मे-रा → *merā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मेरा (*merā*, “my”) descends from Sanskrit *mad-īya* (“of me”), on the first-person root *ma-* — the same *ma-/me-* behind English **me**, **my**, **mine** and Latin *meus*. The Hindi “my” and the English “my” are, at the root, the same word.

Grammar Lens

“My” agrees with the noun. Hindi possessives change to match what is owned: *merā* (masculine), *merī* (feminine), *mere* (plural). *nām* is masculine, so it takes *merā*: *merā nām*. (You will meet *merī* the first time you own a feminine noun.)

2.3 है (*hai*) — “is,” cousin of English *is*

The letters in this word

ह (*ha*) + ै (the *ai-mātrā*) → है (*hai*). One syllable.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

है (*hai*, “is”) ← Sanskrit अस्ति (*asti*, “is”), from Proto-Indo-European **h₁es-* — the root of “to be” across the whole family: English **is**, German *ist*, Latin *est*, Spanish *es*, French *est*. Hindi *hai* is the Indian cousin of the same little verb — “is” really is one word from Ireland to India.

2.4 मेरा नाम ...है (*merā nām ...hai*) — “my name is...”

मेरा (*my*) + नाम (*name*) + है (*is*) = **merā nām ...hai**, “my name is...” *Merā nām Arun hai.* = “My name is Arun.”

2.5. आप / तुम (ĀP / TUM) — “YOU,” RESPECTFUL AND FAMILIAR

Grammar Lens

Word order: the verb goes last. Hindi is a *subject-object-verb* language — literally “my name Arun *is*.” The *hai* sits at the end, where English puts “is” in the middle. Bank this shape: in Hindi, the verb waits until the end of the sentence.

2.5 आप / तुम (*āp* / *tum*) — “you,” respectful and familiar

The letters in this word

आप: the independent vowel आ (*ā*, word-initial) + प (*pa*) → *āp*. तुम: त (*ta*) + उ (the *u*-sign) + म (*ma*) → *tum*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

तुम (*tum*, familiar “you”) ← Sanskrit *tvam*, from PIE *tū — the same root as English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, French *tu*. आप (*āp*, respectful “you”) is a different, honorific word (originally “oneself”).

Grammar Lens

Three levels of “you.” Hindi grades respect in three: *āp* (respectful — strangers, elders, politeness), *tum* (familiar — friends, peers), *tū* (intimate or to a child, and can insult if misused). Each of the earlier tracks had two levels; Hindi has three. For a first meeting, always *āp*.

2.6 क्या (*kyā*) — “what”

The letters in this word

A **conjunct**: क (*ka*) loses its vowel (*halant*) and joins य (*ya*) → क्य (*kya*); add the long-*ā* mātrā → क्या (*kyā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

क्या (*kyā*, “what”) ← Sanskrit *kim* / the interrogative stem *ka-*, from PIE *k^wo- — the same question-root behind English **wh-** words (**what**,

who, which) and Latin *qu-*. Hindi’s question-words nearly all start with this *k-*: *kyā* (what), *kaun* (who), *kab* (when), *kyūn* (why) — the Indian branch of the same family of question-words.

2.7 आपका नाम क्या है? (*āpkā nām kyā hai*) — “what’s your name?”

आपका (*āpkā*, “your”) = आप (you) + का (*kā*, the possessive “of,” the same agreeing *kā/kī/ke* that matches the noun). So आपका नाम क्या है? is literally “**your name what is?**” — Hindi keeps the verb last again, and simply drops the question-word *kyā* into the object slot.

Grammar Lens

Answer it with the sentence you built: *Merā nām Arun hai*. The informal version swaps *āpkā* for *tumhārā*: *tumhārā nām kyā hai?*

2.8 खुशी (*khushī*) — “happiness,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The Hindi “pleased to meet you” is आपसे मिलकर खुशी हुई (*āp-se milkar khushī huī*) — literally “**having met you, happiness happened.**” The key word खुशी (*khushī*, “happiness”) is **not** Sanskrit — it is **Persian** (*khush*, “happy, pleasant”), one of the thousands of Persian words in everyday Hindi. So even introducing yourself draws on Hindi’s *two* vocabularies: Sanskrit (*nām*, *hai*) and Perso-Arabic (*khushī*).

2.9 The whole exchange

Hindi	English
मेरा नाम मीरा है।	My name is Mira.
आपका नाम क्या है?	What’s your name?
मेरा नाम अरुण है।	My name is Arun.
आपसे मिलकर खुशी हुई।	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *nām* (Sanskrit *nāman*, English *name*), *merā* (root *ma-*, English *my*), *hai* (Sanskrit *asti*, English *is*), *kyā* (root *ka-*, English *what*). And two Hindi habits: the **verb goes last**, and “you” has **three** respect-levels. Next chapter: *āp kaise hai?* (“how are you?”) and answering with *thik* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — asking, and answering, how someone is:

आप कैसे हैं? (*āp kaise haiṃ* — “How are you?”)
मैं ठीक हूँ, धन्यवाद! (*maiṃ ṭhīk hūṃ, dhanyavād* — “I’m fine, thank you.”)

Every atom traced, then assembled.

3.1 कैसे (*kaise*) — “how,” another of the k- questions

The letters in this word

क (*ka*) + ै (the *ai-mātrā*) → कै (*kai*); स (*sa*) + े (the *e-mātrā*) → से (*se*). Read कै-से → *kaise*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कैसे (*kaise*, “how”) ← Sanskrit *kīdrśa* (“of what kind”) / the interrogative stem *ka-*, from Proto-Indo-European **k^wo-* — the same question-root behind English **wh-** words and Latin *qu-*. Hindi’s questions nearly all begin with this *k-*: *kyā* (what), *kaun* (who), *kab* (when), *kahāṃ* (where), *kaise* (how).

Grammar Lens

The adjective कैसा (*kaisā*) agrees: *kaisā* (m.), *kaisī* (f.), *kaise* (m. plural / respectful). Because the respectful “you” (*āp*) takes a plural verb,

“how are *you*?” uses the plural कैसे.

3.2 आप कैसे हैं? (*āp kaise haiṃ*) — “how are you?”

हैं is है (*hai*, “is”) + the *anusvāra* ँ → हैं (*haiṃ*), the nasalised plural. So आप कैसे हैं? is literally “**you how are?**” — verb last, and because *āp* is grammatically plural (that is how Hindi shows respect), its verb is the plural *haiṃ*, not *hai*.

Grammar Lens

Respect is plural. To an elder or stranger: *āp kaise haiṃ?* To a friend: *tum kaise ho?* (*ho* is the familiar “are”). Match the “you” to the verb: *āp ... haiṃ*, *tum ... ho*.

3.3 मैं (*maiṃ*) — “I,” the m- of the first person

The letters in this word

म (*ma*) + ैं (*ai*) + the *anusvāra* ँ → मैं (*maiṃ*). One nasal syllable.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मैं (*maiṃ*, “I”) ← Sanskrit *mayā* (“by me”), on the first-person root *ma* — the same root behind Chapter 2’s *merā* (“my”) and behind English **me**, **my**, **mine** and Latin *mē*. Hindi’s “I,” its “my,” and English’s “me/my” grow from one ancient first-person sound.

3.4 हूँ (*hūṃ*) — “am,” cousin of English *am*

The letters in this word

ह (*ha*) + ू (long *u*) → हू (*hū*); the *chandrabinḍu* ँ nasalises → हूँ (*hūṃ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

हूँ (*hūṃ*, “am”) ← Sanskrit *asmi* (“I am”) — the first person of the root that also gave you *hai*. That root, PIE *h₁es-, is “to be” across the family: *asmi* → English **am**, Latin *sum*; *asti* → *hai* / English *is*. The copula lines up person by person: हूँ *am*, है *is*, हैं *are*.

3.5 ठीक (ṭhīk) — “fine,” and how to answer

The letters in this word

ठ (*ṭha*, a **retroflex** *th* — tongue curled to the roof of the mouth) + ी (long *ī*) + क (*ka*) → ठीक. The retroflex ट-ठ-ड series is a hallmark of Indian sound.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ठीक (*ṭhīk*) means “correct, right, fine, exactly, OK.” It is a genuinely **native** Indian word — no European cousin — and one of the most useful in the language. Not every word has a far-flung cognate, and that is worth seeing too: *ṭhīk* is Indian to the core.

Put the atoms together: मैं ठीक हूँ (*maiṃ ṭhīk hūṃ*) — “I am fine” (literally “I fine am”). The whole exchange:

— āp kaise haiṃ? — maiṃ ṭhīk hūṃ, dhanyavād.

3.6 आपका स्वागत है (*āpkā svāgat hai*) — “you’re welcome”

The letters in this word

The key word स्वागत (*svāgat*): the conjunct स्व (स् *s* + व *va* → *sva*) + ग (*ga*) + त (*ta*), with आपका (*āpkā*, “your”) and है (*hai*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

आपका स्वागत है = “your welcome is” → “**you are welcome.**” The heart, स्वागत (*svāgat*), is Sanskrit *su* (“well, good”) + *āgata* (“come”) — “**well come,**” exactly like English *welcome*. Inside it: *su-* the twin of Greek *eu-* (*euphoria*), and *āgata* from the root *gam* (“go/come”), cousin of English **come**. *Svāgatam* survives unchanged in Sanskrit itself.

3.7 The whole exchange

Hindi	English
आप कैसे हैं?	How are you?
मैं ठीक हूँ, धन्यवाद।	I’m fine, thank you.
आपका स्वागत है।	You’re welcome.

Every atom traced: *kaise* (the interrogative *k-*, English *how*), *maiṃ* (root *ma-*, English *me*), *hūṃ* (Sanskrit *asmi*, English *am*), *svāgat* (*su* + *āgata* = “well come”). You now hold the copula trio — *hūṃ* / *hai* / *haiṃ*. Next chapter: the farewells, from the formal *alvidā* to the warm *phir milenge*.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Chapter 1 gave you the grave, formal अलविदा (*alvidā*). Real days end more warmly — with a promise to meet again:

फिर मिलेंगे! (*phir milenge* — “We’ll meet again!”)

4.1 फिर (*phir*) — “again”

The letters in this word

फ (*pha*, an aspirated *p*) + ि (the *i*-mātrā, written before but read after) + र (*ra*) → फिर.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

फिर (*phir*) means “again, then, afterwards” — a native Indo-Aryan adverb with no tidy English cognate, but a familiar *job*: it turns a parting into a promise. English “see you *again*”; Hindi *phir milenge*.

4.2 मिलेंगे (*milenge*) — “(we) will meet”

The letters in this word

मि (*mi*) + ले (*le*) + the *anusvāra* + गे (*ge*) → मिलेंगे (*milenge*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मिलेंगे (*milenge*, “we will meet”) is the future of मिलना (*milnā*, “to meet, to be found”), from Sanskrit *mil-* (“to join, unite”) — the root of *milan* (“a meeting, union”). The ending -एंगे (*-enge*) is the plural future.

Grammar Lens

The future is an ending, not a helper. *mil-* (“meet”) + *-enge* (“we/they will”) → *milenge*. No word like English “will” — the tense lives in the ending, as person lives in *hūṃ/hai/haiṃ*.

4.3 फिर मिलेंगे (*phir milenge*) — “we’ll meet again”

फिर (again) + मिलेंगे (we will meet) = “we’ll meet again.” Where अलविदा (*alvidā*) is grave and final — and, fittingly, a Perso-Arabic word (*al-widā*, “the farewell”) — *phir milenge* is native, everyday, and hopeful, the sibling of the “promise of return” goodbyes across South Asia (Tamil, Bengali, Marathi all say “I’ll come again”).

Grammar Lens

Two registers: अलविदा (formal, final, Perso-Arabic) versus फिर मिलेंगे (everyday, warm, native). Even more casual: *phir milte haiṃ* (“(we) meet again,” present for a near future).

4.4 कल मिलते हैं (*kal milte haiṃ*) — “see you tomorrow”

The letters in this word

क (*ka*) + ल (*la*) → कल (*kal*). Two simple letters, one tricky word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कल (*kal*) means **both “tomorrow” and “yesterday”** — the day on either side of today — from Sanskrit *kāla* (“time”), the very root behind Punjabi’s *akāl* (“timeless”). Context and the verb’s tense tell which: *kal milte haiṃ* (“tomorrow”), *kal milā* (“yesterday”).

Grammar Lens

मिलते हैं (*milte haiṃ*) is literally “(we) meet” — Hindi, like English (“I’m seeing you tomorrow”), uses the present for a scheduled future.

4.5 चलता हूँ (*caltā hūṃ*) — “I’ll be off”**The letters in this word**

च (*ca*) + ल (*la*) + long *ā* → चलता (*caltā*), with हूँ (*hūṃ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

चलता हूँ literally “**I go / I move**” — used like English “I’ll be off.” The verb चलना (*calnā*, “to move, walk, go”) is from Sanskrit *cal-* (“to move, stir”) — the root of *calan* (“circulation”) and *cañcal* (“restless”). Like Bengali *āshi* and Marathi *yeto*, Hindi leaves by saying “I’m *moving*,” never a blunt “I’m leaving.”

Grammar Lens

The verb agrees with the speaker’s gender. A man says चलता हूँ (*caltā hūṃ*); a woman says चलती हूँ (*caltī hūṃ*). The *-tā* / *-tī* ending marks the speaker — a feature English lacks (compare Marathi *yeto* m. / *yete* f.).

4.6 The farewells

Hindi		Register
अलविदा	<i>alvidā</i>	formal, final (Perso-Arabic)
फिर मिलेंगे	<i>phir milenge</i>	everyday, “we’ll meet again”
कल मिलते हैं	<i>kal milte haiṃ</i>	“see you tomorrow”
चलता हूँ	<i>caltā/caltī hūṃ</i>	casual, “I’ll be off”

Roots banked: *milenge* (*mil-* “to join”), *kal* (*kāla* “time,” cousin of Punjabi *akāl*), *caltā* (*cal-* “to move,” the *-tā*/*-tī* marking the speaker’s gender). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *maiṃ hindī boltā hūṃ* — and Hindi’s sentences begin to move.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be.” Now verbs that *act* — and sentences that move:

मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ। (*maiṃ hindī boltā hūṃ* — “I speak Hindi.”)

5.1 बोलना (*bolnā*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

ब (*ba*) + ो (the *o-mātrā*) → बो (*bo*); ल (*la*); ना (*nā*). Read बो·ल·ना → *bolnā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

बोलना (*bolnā*, “to speak”) is a native Indo-Aryan verb (Prakrit *bolla-*, “to utter”). Its ending -ना (*-nā*) is the point: **every** Hindi infinitive ends in *-nā* — *bol-nā* “to speak,” *cal-nā* “to move,” *mil-nā* “to meet.” Strip the *-nā* and you have the **stem** (*bol-*) that takes every other ending.

Grammar Lens

Stem + ending. The stem *bol-* holds the action; endings pin down who and when: *bol-tā* (speaking, m.), *bol-tī* (f.), *bol-o* (speak!, familiar). Every tense is built by adding to a stem like this.

5.2 मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ (*maiṃ hindī boltā hūṃ*) — “I speak Hindi”

मैं (I) + हिंदी (Hindi, the object) + बोलता (speak, m.) + हूँ (am) = literally “I

Hindi speaking am — verb-frame last, as always.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The name हिंदी (*hindī*) is a traveller: from *sindhu* (the river Indus) → Persian *hind* (the land beyond it) → *hindī* (“of Hind”). The same *sindhu* gave Greek *Indos* → English **India**, **Indus**, **Hindu**. The language is named, at two removes, after a river.

Grammar Lens

The present habitual = stem + *-tā/-tī* + “to be.”

	Hindi	
a man	मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ	<i>boltā hūṃ</i>
a woman	मैं हिंदी बोलती हूँ	<i>boltī hūṃ</i>
you (resp.)	आप हिंदी बोलते हैं	<i>bolte haiṃ</i>

The *-tā/-tī/-te* agrees in gender and number; *hūṃ/hai/haiṃ* agrees in person. Two agreements, one small sentence.

5.3 रहना (*rahnā*) — “to live, to stay”

The letters in this word

र (*ra*) + ह (*ha*) + ना (*nā*) → रहना. The familiar infinitive -ना.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

रहना (*rahnā*, “to live, remain, stay”), from Sanskrit *rah-* (“to remain”), covers both “reside” and “keep on”: *maiṃ Dillī meṃ rahtā hūṃ* (“I live in Delhi”), *thīk rahnā* (“stay well”).

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. मैं दिल्ली में रहता हूँ — the word में (*meṃ*, “in”) sits *after* Delhi. Hindi uses **postpositions** where English uses **prepositions**: “Delhi-in I live,” verb last.

5.4 करना (*karnā*) — “to do,” the most useful verb in Hindi

The letters in this word

क (*ka*) + र (*ra*) + ना (*nā*) → करना.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

करना (*karnā*, “to do, make”) is from the Sanskrit root *kṛ* (“to do, make”), PIE *k^wer- — one of the most productive roots in Sanskrit. Its family is already all around you: *karma* (“a thing *done*”), *namaskār* (“the *making* of a bow,” Chapter 1), and the name *Sanskrit* itself (*saṃskṛta*, “put together, perfected”).

Grammar Lens

करना makes verbs out of anything. Noun + *karnā*: *kām karnā* (“work-do” = to work), *bāt karnā* (“talk-do” = to converse), *intizār karnā* (“to wait”). So *maiṃ kām kartā hūṃ* = “I work.”

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Hindi	English
मैं हिंदी बोलता/बोलती हूँ।	I speak Hindi.
मैं दिल्ली में रहता/रहती हूँ।	I live in Delhi.
मैं काम करता/करती हूँ।	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, the *-tā/-tī/-te* that agrees in gender/number, and the *hūṃ/hai/haiṃ* that agrees in person — the verb always last, “in” always after its noun. Roots banked: *bolnā* (Prakrit *bolla-*), *rahnā* (*rah-* “remain”), *karnā* (*kṛ* — the root of *karma*, *namaskār*, *Sanskrit*), and *hindī* (*sindhu*, the Indus). From here, Hindi’s sentences only grow.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Five

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one to five in Hindi and hear the older Sanskrit shapes still sitting inside तीन, चार and पाँच.

Say पाँच beside Sanskrit pañca and point to the moon-dot that is all that survives of the lost nasal consonant.

6.1 एक, दो, तीन, चार, पाँच — the five forms

Five words, and a story about how languages age.

You'll want to know — The five

	Hindi	said
1	एक	<i>ek</i>
2	दो	<i>do</i>
3	तीन	<i>tīn</i>
4	चार	<i>chār</i>
5	पाँच	<i>pāñch</i>

If you did the writing track you'll recognise some pieces: क (Lesson 2), त (Lesson 2), न (Lesson 1), र (Lesson 4), and the ा mātrā (Lesson 3).

Plenty here you haven't been taught to draw yet — ए, च, द, प, the ी and ो mātrās, and the ँ. Read them now; you'll draw them when the writing track reaches them.

The ँ over *pāñch* is a *chandrabindu*, “moon-dot” — it nasalises the vowel, the way French does in *bon*.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “ek, do, tīn, chār, pāñch”
- *Point to:* the familiar क, त, न, र and ा inside the five words
- *Trace it:* the ँ moon-dot over *pāñch*

Before you move on

Count to five in Hindi. (*Ek, do, tīn, chār, pāñch.*) Which mark nasalises the vowel in पँच? (The **chandrabindu**, “moon-dot.”) Do you need to draw every unfamiliar letter today? (**No** — read them now and draw them when their stroke lessons arrive.) Next: watch the Sanskrit forms wear smooth.

6.2 तीन and चार — weight moves from consonants to vowels

The five modern forms did not jump straight from Sanskrit. The Prakrits did most of the wearing-down in between.

You’ll want to know — Put the stages side by side

Sanskrit	→ Prakrit →	Hindi
<i>éka-</i>	<i>ekka</i>	ek
<i>dvá-</i>	<i>do</i>	do
neuter <i>trīṇi</i>	<i>tiṇṇi</i>	tīn
neuter <i>catvāri</i>	<i>cattāri</i>	chār
<i>pāñca</i>	<i>pañca</i>	pāñch

Three and four come from the **neuter** forms. Sanskrit also had masculine *tráyaḥ*, but Hindi *tīn* continues *trīṇi*. The same choice gives *catvāri* → *chār*.

You’ll want to know — The two-step weight trade

1. *trīṇi* → *tiṇṇi*: *r* is lost and **ṇ** **doubles** to make up the weight. Long *ī* shortens because the doubled consonant already makes the syllable heavy.
2. *tiṇṇi* → *tīn*: the double simplifies and the **vowel lengthens** to pay for the lost consonant weight.

The vowel ends long again after being short in the middle. *Ekka* → *ek* shows the second half of the same trade.

This is not decay in a bad sense; it is what heavy use does over two thousand years. The same ancient number wore down on another continent:

	ancient	modern
Latin → Spanish	<i>quattuor</i>	<i>cuatro</i>
Sanskrit → Hindi	<i>catvāri</i>	<i>chār</i>

Same PIE word, two continents, two ordinary histories.

Your turn

- Say it: “trīṇi ... tiṇṇi ... tīn”
- Say it: “catvāri ... cattāri ... chār”
- Compare: “quattuor → cuatro · catvāri → chār”

Before you move on

Which Sanskrit forms underlie *tīn* and *chār*? (**Neuter** *trīṇi* and *catvāri*.) What sits between Sanskrit and Hindi? (The **Prakrits**.) In *trīṇi* → *tiṇṇi* → *tīn*, what trades places? (The lost *r* is paid for by a **double consonant**, then the simplified double by a **long vowel**.) Next: follow the nasal that stayed inside *pāmīch*.

6.3 पाँच — the nasal moved into the vowel

Tīn moved weight between consonants and vowels. *Pāmīch* moves a whole nasal sound into the vowel itself.

You’ll want to know — The nasal that stayed

Sanskrit *pañca* → Hindi *pāmīch*. The **n** did not vanish; Sanskrit’s *ñ* consonant became Hindi’s nasalised *ā*. The ॐ chandrabindu records that nasality above the word.

Say *pāmīch* and *pañca* one after the other. You can hear the nasal migrating backward from its own consonant into the vowel.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “pañca ... pāñch”
- *Hum:* hold the nasal through the vowel in *pāñch*
- *Point to:* ँ, the moon-dot that records it

Before you move on

Did the nasal in *pañca* disappear? (**No** — it moved into the vowel.)
 What records it in पञ्च? (The **chandrabindu**.) Count one to five
 once more. (*Ek, do, tīn, chār, pāñch*.)

Chapter 7

Yes and No

By the end of this chapter: I can say yes and no in Hindi and use नहीं to negate a whole sentence.

Say नहीं, put it in front of a verb — मैं नहीं जानता — and hear the single PIE *ne behind no, non and nein.

7.1 हँ (hām̐) — yes

A single open vowel, said through the nose — that’s Hindi’s yes.

You’ll want to know — The word

हँ = yes, said hām̐. It’s the letter ह (h) with the ा sign for long ā, and — the key mark — the ँ on top: the **chandrabindu**, the “moon-dot.” It does one thing: it **nasalises** the vowel. So hām̐ isn’t “hah” but a humming hāā̃, the sound sent up through the nose, the way French does in *bon*.

(Don’t confuse the moon-dot ँ with the plain dot ं *anusvara* you’ll see in the next word — both nasalise, but the moon-dot rides a vowel that has nothing above it, like ा.)

You’ll want to know — Saying it politely

A bare hām̐ is a normal, friendly yes. To an elder, a stranger, or anyone you’d show respect, Hindi adds the honorific जी (jī):

जी हँ — jī hām̐ — “yes” (polite)

jī on its own is already a respectful “yes.” You met -jī on names; here it warms up a plain yes into a courteous one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hām” — let the *ā* hum through your nose
- polite — “jī hām”
- spot the mark — the moon-dot ँ is what nasalises it

Before you move on

How do you say yes in Hindi? (**hām**, हँ.) What does the **chandra-bindu** ँ do to the vowel? (**Nasalises** it — sends it through the nose.) How do you make *hām* polite? (Add जी — *jī hām*.) Next: नहीं, no.

7.2 नहीं (nahīm) — no / not

Hindi’s “no” carries a sound so old it also sits inside German and Latin.

You’ll want to know — The word

नहीं = **no**, said **nahīm** — न (na) + ह (h) + ी (long *i*) + the ँ *anusvara* that nasalises the end. The heart of it is that first syllable **na**, which is Hindi’s ancient negator, straight from **Sanskrit na**.

You’ll want to know — The oldest “no” you’ll meet

That **na** is not just Sanskrit’s — it is the same negative root that runs across nearly every Indo-European language, all descended from one ancient sound,

PIE *ne:

from ***ne**

Sanskrit <i>na</i>	→ Hindi nahīm
Latin <i>nōn</i>	→ Spanish no , French non
Germanic	→ German nein , English no / not

German’s *nein* carries this exact idea (“not one”); here it is again at the other end of the family, in Hindi. The word for *no* is one of the most stubbornly unchanged things human languages have.

You'll want to know — One word, two jobs

Like Spanish *no*, **nahīm** is both the **answer** and the **sentence-negator**:

- **answer**: आप आ रहे हैं? — नहीं. (“Are you coming?” — “No.”)
- **negator**: मैं नहीं जानता — “I do **not** know.”

So this single word gives you both “no” and how to make a sentence negative.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nahīm” — nasal at the end, from the *anusvara*
- the ancient root — “na... nōn... nein... no”: one PIE *ne*
- as a negator — “maĩ nahīm jāntā”, “I don’t know”

Before you move on

How do you say no in Hindi? (**nahīm**, नहीं.) What Sanskrit word is its core, and what ancient sound is that from? (**na**, from **PIE *ne**.) Which other course words share that root? (Latin *nōn*, German *nein*, English *no/not* — and Spanish/French *no/non*.) Besides “no,” what else does *nahīm* do? (It **negates a sentence** — *maĩ nahīm jāntā*, “I don’t know.”)

Chapter 8

Please

By the end of this chapter: I can say please in Hindi, both with कृपया and with the polite verb ending everyday speech actually prefers.

Say कृपया with its vocalic ऋ, unpack it as ‘of your compassion’, then switch to the everyday बैठिए, ‘please sit’.

8.1 कृपया (kṛpayā) — please (kindly)

Hindi’s dictionary word for “please” is really the word **compassion** in disguise — and it’s more formal than you might expect.

You’ll want to know — The word

कृपया = **please**, literally “**kindly / graciously**.” It’s built on the Sanskrit noun कृपा (*kṛpā*), “**grace, compassion, mercy**” — so asking with *kṛpayā* means, at heart, “of your compassion.”

That places Hindi in good company: **Arabic** asks *min faḍlik* (“from your **grace**”), and the Dravidian languages ask with *daya* (“**compassion**”). A whole swathe of Asia says *please* by naming the kindness it hopes for — a different instinct from French’s “if it **pleases** you.”

The first letter hides a sound you met in the syllabary track: कृ is *ka* carrying the **vocalic r** (the ृ mark) — *kṛ*, the same *r* vowel Sanskrit and the Dravidian scripts share.

You’ll want to know — Be honest about how it’s used

Here’s the catch a textbook often hides: कृपया is **formal and bookish**. You’ll see it on signs and hear it in announcements (“*kṛpayā* mind the gap”),

but in everyday speech Hindi speakers rarely say it. Real politeness usually rides on **the verb** instead — the respectful request ending -इए / -इएगा (-*iye* / -*iyegā*): *baiṭhiye* “please sit,” *sunīye* “please listen.” And very often, people simply say the English word “**please.**”

So learn *kṛpayā* to **read** it and to be formally polite — but know that the living “please” of Hindi is baked into the verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kṛpayā” — kṛ with the vocalic r, then -payā
- the root — “kṛpā = compassion” → “of your compassion”
- the everyday way — the verb ending: “baiṭhiye” = “please sit”

Before you move on

What is the formal Hindi word for please? (कृपया *kṛpayā*.) What does its root *kṛpā* mean, and which other languages ask the same way? (“**Grace / compassion**” — like Arabic *min faḍlik* and Dravidian *daya*.) Is *kṛpayā* what people usually say out loud? (**No** — it’s formal; everyday politeness rides on the verb ending -*iye*/-*iyegā*, or people say English “please.”)

Chapter 9

Sorry

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise in Hindi with माफ़ कीजिए and reach for its more formal cousin when the moment calls for it.

Say माफ़ कीजिए as ‘please do forgiveness’, then क्षमा करें when the setting is formal.

9.1 माफ़ कीजिए (māf kījiye) — please forgive me / sorry

You already know the formal कृपया (kr̥payā), “please.” Hindi’s everyday “sorry” is built the same way you build a request: **name the kindness, ask for it to be done.**

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- माफ़ (māf) = “**forgiven, pardoned**” — not a native Hindi word at all! It’s borrowed through **Persian** from **Arabic** عفو (‘afw), “to pardon, efface, wipe away [a wrong].” Look closely at the spelling: the dot under फ़ (called a **nuqtā**) turns the plain *pha* sound into **fa** — Hindi’s way of writing sounds that arrived from Persian and Arabic.
- कीजिए (kījiye) = the **respectful imperative** “**please do**,” from करना (karnā), “to do.”

So माफ़ कीजिए is literally “**please do forgiven[-ness]**” — *please make [this] forgiven*. It’s the same light-verb move you’ve already met: naming a state (forgiveness, kindness, compassion) and asking someone to *do* it.

You'll want to know — Be honest about register — and about English creeping in

माफ़ कीजिए is warm and genuinely everyday — but Hindi keeps a **more formal, Sanskritic** cousin for writing and ceremony: क्षमा करें (*kṣamā karēni*), “please grant **kṣamā**” — from Sanskrit क्षमा (*kṣamā*), “patience, forbearance, forgiveness.” Where *kṛpayā* was the bookish “please,” **kṣamā karēm** is the bookish “sorry.”

And here's the honest twist: in casual conversation, many Hindi speakers simply say the **English word “sorry”** outright — it has been fully adopted into everyday Hindi, the same way English “please” sometimes stands in for *kṛpayā*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “māf” — forgiven — then “kījiye,” please do
- the whole phrase — “māf kījiye” = please forgive me
- the formal cousin — “kṣamā karēm”

Before you move on

What does माफ़ कीजिए literally mean? (“**Please do forgiven[-ness]**” — *māf* “forgiven” + *kījiye* “please do.”) Where does *māf* come from? (**Borrowed via Persian from Arabic** *ʿafw*, “to pardon.”) What's the more formal, Sanskritic cousin? (क्षमा करें *kṣamā karēm*, from *kṣamā* “patience/forgiveness.”) What do many Hindi speakers just say instead, casually? (**The English word “sorry.”**)

Chapter 10

Days of the Week

***By the end of this chapter:** I can name all seven days of the week in Hindi and say which planet each day is named for.*

Recite सोमवार through रविवार end to end, naming Saturn's day and the Sun's day to close the planet-week.

10.1 सोमवार to शुक्रवार — Hindi's own planet-week

You've seen Spanish, Latin, and French name their weekdays for planet-gods. Here's the surprise: **Hindi does too** — with its own, independent set of gods.

You'll want to know — The pattern: [deity] + वार, “day”

Every Hindi weekday is a **deity's name** plus वार (*vār*), “day” (Sanskrit *vāra*):

Hindi	literally	deity/planet	day
सोमवार (<i>somavār</i>)	Soma’s day	the Moon	Monday
मंगलवार (<i>maṅgalvār</i>)	Mangala’s day	Mars	Tuesday
बुधवार (<i>budhvār</i>)	Budha’s day	Mercury	Wednesday
गुरुवार (<i>guruvār</i>)	Guru’s day	Jupiter (<i>Bṛhaspati</i> , called “Guru,” teacher of the gods)	Thursday
शुक्रवार (<i>śukravār</i>)	Śukra’s day	Venus	Friday

You’ll want to know — Be honest about where this system came from

This is **the same seven-body idea** as Rome’s planetary week — Sun, Moon, Mercury, Venus, Mars, Jupiter, Saturn — and it is **not** an isolated Indian invention: historians trace it, ultimately, to a shared source in **Babylonian astronomy**, and most accounts hold that it reached both Rome and India through the **same Hellenistic-Greek channel** of transmission (India’s own horoscopic-astrology texts, like the *Yavanajātaka*, are explicitly adapted from Greek originals). The exact path and timing into India are still debated among historians of astronomy, but the system isn’t a case of Rome and India copying each other directly — both are more like **cousins**, downstream of one much older shared idea of the sky.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “somavār” — Soma/Moon’s day — then “maṅgalvār,” Mangala/Mars’s day
- the pattern — “[deity] + vār” = [deity]’s day
- “guruvār” — Thursday — Bṛhaspati, called “Guru”

Before you move on

What does every Hindi weekday end in, and what does it mean? (वार *vār*, “day.”) Which planet is गुरुवार, and what title does its deity carry? (**Jupiter** — the deity Br̥haspati, called “**Guru**,” teacher of the gods — an ancient title Br̥haspati bears, not the source of the word itself.) Did Hindi borrow its planet-week from Rome? (**No** — both likely trace back through **Hellenistic Greece** to a shared **Babylonian** astronomical source, though the exact route into India is still debated.)

10.2 शनिवार and रविवार — Saturday and Sunday, no rewrite needed

You’ve met five Hindi weekdays, each a deity’s name plus वार (*vār*), “day.” The last two complete the set — and here, unlike Spanish or French, **nothing ever got renamed**.

You’ll want to know — The last two days

- शनिवार (*śanivār*) = “**Śani’s day**” — **Saturn**.
- रविवार (*ravivār*) = “**Ravi’s day**” — the **Sun** (*Ravi*, one of the Sun’s many Sanskrit names).

You’ll want to know — Be honest about the contrast with Spanish and French

Remember: Spanish’s **sábado/domingo** and French’s **samedi/dimanche** are **not** simple planet-names — Christianity renamed both (Saturn’s day became the *Sabbath*; the Sun’s day became “*the Lord’s day*”). Hindi’s week-end went through **no such rewrite**: शनिवार and रविवार are still, today, plainly “Saturn’s day” and “Sun’s day” — the full planet-week, all seven days, standing untouched by any later religious relabeling.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śanivār” — Saturn’s day — then “ravivār,” Sun’s day

- the whole week — “somavār, maṅgalvār, budhvār, guruvār, śukravār, śanivār, ravivār”
- the contrast — Spanish/French renamed their weekend; Hindi never did

Before you move on

What do शनिवार and रविवार literally mean? (“**Saturn’s day**” and “**Sun’s day**.”) How is Hindi’s weekend different from Spanish’s or French’s? (**No religious rewrite ever happened** — Hindi kept the plain planet-names for all seven days, while Spanish/French swapped in *Sabbath* / *Lord’s day* for the weekend.)

Chapter 11

Four Core Colours

By the end of this chapter: I can name black, white, red and blue in Hindi and say which of them came from Sanskrit and which from Persian.

Say लाल and नीला beside काला and सफ़ेद, keeping nīla and 'indigo' honestly linked by trade rather than by sound.

11.1 काला, सफ़ेद (kāḷā, safed) — black and white

Hindi's word for black hides something bigger inside it: the very same word Sanskrit uses for **time itself** — and for death.

You'll want to know — काला — black, time, and death, tangled together

काला (kāḷā) = “**black**,” from Sanskrit काल (kāla), a word that covers both “**black/dark**” and “**time**.” Sanskrit's own tradition ties the two together poetically — **time devours everything**, and that devouring is imagined as *dark* — and the same word names the fierce goddess **Kālī** (“the black/dark one”) and stands as an epithet of **Yama**, the god of death. Be honest, though: whether “black” and “time” are truly **one and the same root**, or two separate ancient words that Sanskrit poetry and theology later **fused** into a single idea, is a real, still-debated question among linguists — the cultural connection is certain; the precise etymology underneath it is not.

You'll want to know — सफ़ेद — a Persian loan

सफ़ेद (safed) = “**white**” — borrowed from **Persian** (سفید safēd), the same kind of Persian-into-Hindi borrowing you've already met in माफ़ (māf, “for-

given,” from the “sorry” lesson). Notice the **नुक्ता** (*nuqtā*, the dot under फ): it turns *pha* into **fa**, the tell-tale mark of a sound that arrived from Persian or Arabic.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kāla” — time/black/death, then “kāla” — black
- “safed” — white, a Persian loan
- the dot — **नुक्ता** under फ turns pha into fa

Before you move on

What does **काला**’s root **काल** (*kāla*) also mean, besides “black”? (“**Time**” — and by extension, **death**; the same word names the goddess **Kālī** and Yama’s epithet **Kāla**.) Is it settled that “black” and “time” are the same root? (**No** — the cultural link is real and ancient, but linguists still debate whether it’s one true root or two words later fused.) Where does **सफ़ेद** come from? (**Persian** *safēd* — the same kind of loan as *māf*, “sorry.”)

11.2 लाल, नीला (*lāl, nīlā*) — a gemstone’s name, and India’s dye

One more color pair, and one more Persian loan — plus a Sanskrit word connected to why English itself says “**indigo**.”

You’ll want to know — लाल — named for a gem, not a color

लाल (*lāl*) = “**red**” — borrowed from Persian لال (*lāl*, properly *la^ʿl*, with a middle *ʿayn* the Hindi/Persian pronunciation *lāl* smooths over), which originally named a specific **deep-red gemstone** (a ruby or spinel), and only later widened to mean the color itself. Hindi’s everyday word for “red” started life as a jeweler’s word.

You’ll want to know — नीला — Sanskrit’s dark blue, and the world’s word for indigo

नीला (*nīlā*) = “**blue**,” from Sanskrit नील (*nīla*), “dark blue” — also the name of the **indigo plant** and its dye. Here’s the honest, careful version of a famous connection: English “**indigo**” does **not** come from *nīla* by sound change. It comes from **Greek** *indikón*, simply meaning “**the Indian [thing]**” — because Greek and Roman traders imported the blue dye **from India**. So *nīlā* and “indigo” aren’t the same word evolving — they’re two **separate** words for the same dye, one Indian (*nīla*, describing the color) and one foreign (*indikón*, describing the dye’s *origin*). The connection is real, but it’s a connection of **history and trade**, not of sound.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lāl” — red, originally a gemstone’s name
- “nīlā” — blue, from Sanskrit *nīla*
- the honest distinction — *nīla* and “indigo” are two different words linked by trade, not by sound

Before you move on

What did लाल originally name, before it meant “red”? (**A deep red gemstone**, borrowed from Persian.) Does English “**indigo**” come directly from Sanskrit नील *nīla*? (**No** — indigo is from Greek *indikón*, “the Indian [thing],” describing where the dye came from; *nīla* and “indigo” are two separate words connected by history, not by sound change.)

Chapter 12

Family

By the end of this chapter: I can name my father, mother, brother and sister in Hindi.

Say भाई and बहन beside पिता and माता, and name which one is a true cousin of English 'brother' and which is not.

12.1 पिता, माता (pitā, mātā) — father and mother, cousins across a huge family

You've already met Latin **pater/māter** and their English cousins **father/mother** — all descending from one ancient shared word. Hindi keeps a cousin of its own, in the very same family.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- पिता (pitā) = “**father**” — Sanskrit पितृ (pitṛ), from the **same PIE root, *ph₂tēr***, as Latin *pater* and English *father*.
- माता (mātā) = “**mother**” — Sanskrit मातृ (mātr), from *méh₂tēr*, the same root as Latin *māter* and English *mother*.

So *pitā* and *father* are, at the deepest level, the **same ancient word** — reaching you here through Sanskrit rather than through Latin or Germanic, one more branch of the same very old family tree.

You'll want to know — Be honest about register — the everyday words

पिता/माता are correct, respectable Hindi — but the words you'll hear **most often in daily life** are different: बाप (*bāp*, “father,” an everyday/colloquial word) and माँ (*māṁi*, “mother,” universally the warm, everyday word — closer to English “mom” than “mother”). These aren't uncertain outliers, either — they're **also** Sanskrit-descended, just by a different path than *pitā/mātā*: बाप traces through Prakrit to Sanskrit वप् (vaptṛ, “father,” a different Sanskrit root from *pitṛ*), while माँ is a genuine **doublet** of *mātā* — both come from the very same Sanskrit *mātr*, just worn down along a more colloquial Prakrit line.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pitā, mātā” — the Sanskrit-descended, formal pair
- “bāp, māṁi” — the everyday, spoken pair
- the deep cousin — “pitā and father are the same ancient PIE word”

Before you move on

What are पिता and माता cousins of, in Latin and English? (**Pater/father** and **māter/mother** — all from the same PIE roots.) What are the everyday, spoken words instead? (बाप *bāp* and माँ *māṁi*.) Are *bāp* and *māṁi* also Sanskrit-descended? (**Yes** — *bāp* traces to Sanskrit *vaptṛ*, a different root from *pitṛ*; *māṁi* is a genuine **doublet** of *mātā*, both from *mātr*.)

12.2 भाई, बहन (bhāī, bahin) — one cousin word, one different word entirely

You've met *frāter* and *soror* as PIE cousins of “brother” and “sister.” Hindi's pair has a genuine surprise hiding in it: only **one** of these two continues that ancient family.

You'll want to know — भाई — the expected cousin

भाई (*bhāī*) = “**brother**” — from Sanskrit भ्रातृ (*bhrātr*), which **does** continue the same PIE root, *b^hréh₂tēr*, as Latin *frāter* and English *brother*. This one is exactly what you'd expect: one more cousin in the same old family.

You'll want to know — बहन — NOT the expected cousin

Sanskrit did have a direct PIE-cognate word for “sister” too: स्वसृ (*svasr*), the very cousin of Latin *soror* and English *sister*. But that word **faded from use**. In its place, Sanskrit built a **different** word, भगिनी (*bhaginī*) — and *that* word, not *svasr*, is the confirmed ancestor of Hindi's everyday बहन (*bahin*). (Where *bhaginī* itself comes from is the less certain part: it's often explained as भग (*bhaga*, “a share, good fortune”) plus a feminine suffix, “the one who shares” — but Sanskritists don't all agree on this, and some suspect it's a reshaping of an older form avoiding an unrelated, indelicate sense of *bhaga*. That deeper question is worth a linguist's extra check; the *bahin* ≠ *svasr* finding itself is solid.)

So Hindi's brother/sister pair is **lopsided** in its ancestry: *bhāī* genuinely continues the ancient PIE word; *bahin* comes from an entirely different Sanskrit formation that **replaced** the PIE-cognate word before Hindi ever inherited it. (Sanskrit-to-Hindi sound history has plenty of non-obvious turns.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhāī” — brother — the true PIE cousin of “brother”
- “bahin” — sister — from *bhaginī*, “the one who shares,” NOT from the PIE word for sister
- the asymmetry — one cousin, one completely different word

Before you move on

Does भाई continue the same ancient root as English “brother”? (**Yes** — Sanskrit *bhrātr* < PIE *b^hréh₂tēr*, same as Latin *frāter*.) Does बहन continue the same ancient root as English “sister”? (**No** — Sanskrit's PIE-cognate word, *svasr*, faded; *bahin* comes from भगिनी *bhaginī*, an unrelated Sanskrit formation — often glossed “the one who shares,”

though *bhaginī*'s own deeper origin is itself debated.)

Chapter 13

Head and Hand

By the end of this chapter: I can name the head and the hand in Hindi and trace both back to the Sanskrit words they wore down from.

Say हाथ, then हस्त, then the shape of the change between them: the -st-cluster simplifies and the vowel lengthens.

13.1 सिर (sir) — the head

A short, everyday word — and, once you look, a worn-down piece of a much older Sanskrit word you may recognize from yoga or anatomy.

You'll want to know — The word

सिर (*sir*) = “**head**” — from Sanskrit शिरस् (*śiras*), “head.” Centuries of everyday use wore the word down from the fuller, formal Sanskrit shape to the short, simple *sir* you use every day.

Sanskrit's *śiras* root is still alive in more formal/technical registers too — related *śīrṣa*-based vocabulary shows up in yoga and Ayurvedic anatomical terms (as in poses and positions named for the head), even while everyday Hindi kept the shorter, worn-down *sir*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sir” — head
- the fuller Sanskrit source — “śiras”

- worn down over time — “śiras → sir”

Before you move on

What does सिर mean, and what Sanskrit word is it worn down from? (“**Head**” — from शिरस् *śiras*.) Where else does this root show up, in a more formal register? (**Yoga/anatomical terms** built on the related *śīrṣa* root.)

13.2 हाथ (hāth) — the hand

This word looks nothing like its Sanskrit ancestor at first glance — but the change between them follows a real, traceable pattern, not a random drift.

You’ll want to know — The word

हाथ (*hāth*) = “**hand**” — from Sanskrit हस्त (*hasta*), “hand.”

You’ll want to know — The honest sound-change story

Getting from *hasta* to *hāth* isn’t one clean step — it passed through **Prakrit** (the everyday spoken languages that stood between Sanskrit and modern Hindi) along the way: Sanskrit’s **-st-** consonant cluster regularly simplified in Prakrit into a **geminate** (doubled), **aspirated** consonant (giving an intermediate form like *hattha*). Later, as that doubled consonant simplified further down to modern Hindi’s single **-th-**, the **vowel just before it lengthened** — *a* becoming *ā* — as if to make up for the sound that was lost. That’s the general shape of the change: **- st- → (Prakrit geminate aspirate) → single aspirate + a longer vowel** — a recognized pattern in how Sanskrit consonant clusters evolved into modern Hindi, not a one-off coincidence for this word alone.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hāth” — hand
- the Sanskrit source — “hasta”

- the shape of the change — “-st- cluster → simplified consonant + longer vowel”

Before you move on

What does हाथ mean, and what Sanskrit word is it from? (“**Hand**” — from हस्त *hasta*.) What’s the general shape of the sound change between them? (**Sanskrit’s -st- cluster simplified** through Prakrit into a **geminate** aspirated consonant (*hattha*), which later simplified to a single consonant — and the vowel before it **lengthened** to compensate.)

Chapter 14

Seasons

By the end of this chapter: I can name all six traditional Indian seasons in Hindi, including the one the four-season frame has no word for.

Say all six ऋतु in order and point to वर्षा, the monsoon season no Western four-season label maps onto.

14.1 वसंत, ग्रीष्म, वर्षा, शरद्, हेमंत, शिशिर — six seasons, not four

European languages generally split the year into **four** seasons. Hindi’s own tradition doesn’t — it recognizes **six**, and this isn’t extra vocabulary bolted onto a four-season frame. It’s a genuinely different way of dividing the year.

You’ll want to know — The six ऋतु (ṛtu, “seasons”)

Hindi	rough Western match
वसंत (<i>vasant</i>)	spring
ग्रीष्म (<i>grīṣma</i>)	summer
वर्षा (<i>varṣā</i>)	monsoon/rains — no Western equivalent
शरद् (<i>śarad</i>)	autumn
हेमंत (<i>hemant</i>)	pre-winter/late autumn
शिशिर (<i>śiśir</i>)	deep winter

This six-season calendar, ऋतु (*ṛtu*), is rooted in classical Sanskrit tradition and Indian astronomy/astrology, and it maps onto the actual climate

of much of the Indian subcontinent far better than a four-season frame does: the **monsoon** (*varṣā*) is a real, distinct, and hugely important season there — not a subdivision of “summer” or “autumn,” but its own season with no clean Western counterpart. And the cold season splits into **two** stages, *hemant* (the onset) and *śiśir* (deep winter), rather than being lumped into one “winter.”

You’ll want to know — Be honest: don’t force the four-season frame onto this

It would be a mistake to just match these six words one-to-one against Spanish’s four or French’s four the way earlier lessons matched *tala* to *talai*. The **structure itself is different** — six real seasons, not four plus two extras. Everyday spoken Hindi *does* also use looser, more casual four-part talk about seasons (borrowing straightforwardly from the idea of “summer,” “winter,” etc.), but the traditional, classical ऋतु system is genuinely six-fold, and it’s worth learning as its own thing rather than squeezed into someone else’s frame.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six — “vasant, grīṣma, varṣā, śarad, hemant, śiśir”
- the one with no Western match — “varṣā,” the monsoon
- the honest point — six seasons is a different STRUCTURE, not extra vocabulary

Before you move on

How many seasons does Hindi’s traditional ऋतु calendar recognize? (**Six**, not four.) Which season has no clean Western equivalent, and why? (वर्षा *varṣā*, the **monsoon** — a real, distinct season central to the subcontinent’s climate.) Is this just extra vocabulary added to a four-season frame? (**No** — it’s a genuinely different structural division of the year.)

Chapter 15

Water and Bread

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for water and bread in Hindi and say what पानी literally means.

Ask for पानी and रोटी, then unpack पानी as 'the drinkable one' — pā, to drink, plus -nīya, fit for.

15.1 पानी, रोटी (pānī, roṭī) — water (the “drinkable thing”) and bread

Hindi’s everyday word for water isn’t the ancient Sanskrit word you might expect — it names water by what you **do** with it, not by what it **is**.

You’ll want to know — पानी — “the drinkable thing”

पानी (pānī) = “**water**.” Sanskrit actually has older, more “basic” words for water — आप् (āp) and जल (jala) among them — but Hindi’s everyday word descends from neither. It comes from Sanskrit पानीय (pānīya), built on the verb पा (pā), “**to drink**,” plus a suffix meaning roughly “**fit for**.” So pānīya, and Hindi’s pānī after it, literally means “**the drinkable thing**” — water defined by its use, not named as a substance in its own right.

You’ll want to know — रोटी — bread, honestly uncertain in origin

रोटी (roṭī) = “**bread, flatbread**” — the everyday word for the flatbreads (roti, chapati-style breads) central to North Indian meals. Be honest: unlike pānī, roṭī’s deeper history is **not cleanly traced** back through Sanskrit the

way many everyday Hindi words are. It comes through Prakrit रोट्ट (roṭṭa, “a kind of bread”) from Sanskrit रोटिका (roṭikā); beyond that, one proposal (Turner’s Indo-Aryan dictionary) tentatively links it to a root meaning “**to strike / to press or crush**” — perhaps evoking the pounding and flattening of dough — but this is genuinely uncertain, one guess among scholars rather than a settled chain. Worth knowing honestly rather than forcing a confident derivation that isn’t there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pānī” — water, “the drinkable thing”
- the root — “pā,” to drink, + “-nīya,” fit for
- “roṭī” — bread, flatbread

Before you move on

Does पानी come from Sanskrit’s ancient water-words, *āp* or *jala*? (**No** — from पानीय *pānīya*, “the drinkable thing,” from पा *pā*, “to drink.”) Is रोटी’s etymology as clearly traced as *pānī*’s? (**No** — it traces to Prakrit *roṭṭa* < Sanskrit *roṭikā*, but beyond that the deeper root is genuinely uncertain — one proposal links it to “striking/pressing” dough, not a settled chain.)

Chapter 16

Months

By the end of this chapter: I can name the twelve months in Hindi and explain why the festivals move against the Gregorian calendar.

Say जनवरी through दिसंबर, then name Chaitra and Vaiśākh and explain that the festivals are dated by Vikram Samvat instead.

16.1 जनवरी to दिसंबर — borrowed names, and a second calendar underneath

Like Arabic, Hindi doesn't have just **one** set of months — everyday civil life and traditional/religious life run on **two different calendars**.

You'll want to know — The Gregorian months — recent, borrowed

For dates, school, business, and government, Hindi uses month names borrowed straightforwardly from **English**:

जनवरी, फ़रवरी, मार्च, अप्रैल, मई, जून, जुलाई, अगस्त, सितंबर, अक्टूबर, नवंबर, दिसंबर (*janvarī, farvarī, mārc, aprail, maī, jūn, julāī, agast, sitambar, ak-tūbar, navambar, disambar*) — you can hear “January,” “March,” “August” right through the Hindi pronunciation. This is a modern civil borrowing, not an ancient Sanskrit system.

You'll want to know — Be honest: the traditional calendar is a genuinely different structure

Hindu tradition keeps its **own**, much older lunisolar calendar — विक्रम संवत् (*Vikram Samvat*) — with twelve **different** month names: चैत्र, वैशाख, ज्येष्ठ, आषाढ़, श्रावण, भाद्रपद, आश्विन, कार्तिक, मार्गशीर्ष, पौष, माघ, फाल्गुन (*Chaitra, Vaiśākh, Jyēṣṭha, Āṣāḍh, Śrāvaṇ, Bhādrapad, Āśvin, Kārtik, Mārgaśīrṣ, Pauṣ, Māgh, Phālgun*).

This isn't just a second set of labels for the same twelve solar months — these months are tied to the **six-ṛtu** seasonal calendar from the seasons lesson (in the traditional/classical scheme, each pair of Vikram Samvat months corresponds to one of the six *ṛtu*), and major festivals (Holi, Diwali, and many others) are dated by **this** calendar, not the Gregorian one — which is why their Gregorian-calendar date shifts from year to year.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “janvarī, mārc, agast” — hear the borrowed English names
- the traditional calendar — “Chaitra, Vaiśākh, Jyēṣṭha”
- the honest point — festivals shift on the Gregorian calendar because they're dated by Vikram Samvat instead

Before you move on

Where do Hindi's everyday civil month names come from? (**Borrowed from English** — *janvarī, mārc, agast...*) What traditional calendar runs alongside it, and what is it tied to? (**Vikram Samvat** — tied to the **six ṛtu** seasons, not the four-season Western frame.) Why do festivals like Holi and Diwali fall on different Gregorian dates each year? (**They're dated by Vikram Samvat**, a different calendar system entirely.)

Chapter 17

Noon and Midnight

By the end of this chapter: I can say noon and midnight in Hindi and explain the old three-hour pahar hidden inside दोपहर.

Say दोपहर as 'two pahars' and आधी रात as 'half night', contrasting one built on an old time-unit with one built plainly.

17.1 दोपहर, आधी रात — noon by an old clock, midnight fully transparent

Hindi's word for noon hides a whole traditional timekeeping system inside it — one very different from hours and minutes.

You'll want to know — दोपहर — “two pahars”

दोपहर (*dopahar*) = “**noon, midday**” — literally “**two** (*do*) + **pahar**.” A पहर (*pahar*, from Sanskrit *prahara*) is a traditional Indian unit of time, roughly **three hours** long, with the day traditionally divided into eight *pahars* (four for daytime, four for night), counted from sunrise. Noon falls right around the end of the **second** daytime *pahar* after sunrise — so *do-pahar*, “two pahars [in],” became the everyday word for midday. (This traditional pahar-based account is the standard one, though — as with any folk-timekeeping etymology this old — treat the exact number of pahars as the general shape of the story rather than a precisely dated fact.)

You’ll want to know — आधी रात — fully transparent “half night”

आधी रात (*ādhī rāt*) = “**midnight**,” literally “**half night**” — आधी (*ādhī*, the feminine form of आधा, *ādhā*, “half”) + रात (*rāt*, “night”). No erosion, no double meaning — structurally identical to Latin’s *media nox* and Spanish’s *medianoche*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pahar” — a traditional ~3-hour watch — then “do-pahar,” two pahars, noon
- “ādhī rāt” — half night, midnight
- the contrast — dopahar counts an old time-unit; ādhī rāt is plainly “half” + “night”

Before you move on

What does दोपहर literally mean, and what’s a *pahar*? (“**Two pahars**” — a *pahar* being a traditional ~3-hour time-unit, with noon falling around the end of the second one after sunrise.) What does आधी रात literally mean? (“**Half night**” — *ādhī* “half” + *rāt* “night,” fully transparent, just like Latin’s *media nox*.)

Chapter 18

Telling Time

By the end of this chapter: I can tell someone what o'clock it is in Hindi.

Say एक बज रहा है and दो बज रहे हैं — the hour striking, exactly as the ghaṇṭā bell once did.

18.1 घंटा — “hour,” literally “bell”

Here's a word that wears its history on its sleeve: Hindi's word for “hour” is the exact same word as “bell.”

You'll want to know — घंटा — bell AND hour, one word

घंटा (*ghaṇṭā*) = “**hour**” — and it means “**bell, gong**” just as commonly. It comes from Sanskrit घण्टा (*ghaṇṭā*), “bell, gong.” The connection isn't a coincidence: temples, towns, and later clock towers historically marked the passing of time by **striking a bell** — the hour was announced by sound, not read off a face — so the word for the bell itself came to mean the unit of time it announced. Compare this to English **o'clock**, itself a worn-down “**of the clock**,” or French's **il est ... heures**: different languages, but time-telling vocabulary keeps circling back to the *instrument* used to mark it.

Grammar Lens: बजना — “to strike, to toll”

Hindi tells the time with the verb बजना (*bajnā*), “**to strike, to toll**” — the same imagery as a bell striking the hour:

एक बज रहा है। — “It is one o'clock.” (literally “**one is striking**”) दो बज रहे हैं। — “It is two o'clock.” (literally “**two are**”)

striking”)

Just like Spanish switches from singular *es* to plural *son* after “one,” Hindi switches बज रहा है (singular) to बज रहे हैं (plural) once the count passes one — matching the number, not just tacking on “o’clock.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ghaṇṭā” — hour, also “bell”
- “ek baj raha hai” — it is one o’clock, “one is striking”
- “do baj rahe hain” — it is two o’clock, “two are striking”

Before you move on

What does घंटा literally mean besides “hour”? (“**Bell, gong**” — from Sanskrit *ghaṇṭā*.) Why did “bell” come to mean “hour”? (Because clocks/towns historically **struck a bell** to announce the hour.) What verb does Hindi use to tell the time, and what does it literally mean? (बजना, *bajnā* — “to strike, to toll,” as in *ek baj raha hai*, “one is striking.”)

Chapter 19

Asking Someone's Age

By the end of this chapter: I can ask someone's age in Hindi and give my own in the belonging-to-years shape Hindi uses.

Ask तुम कितने साल के हो? *and answer* मैं बीस साल का हूँ, *with* के/का *carrying the 'belonging to' work.*

19.1 उम्र — the same word as Arabic

You just met Arabic's *ʿumr*. Hindi's everyday word for “age” is the **exact same word**, carried through Persian.

You'll want to know — उम्र — a Perso-Arabic loan, and a native alternative

उम्र (*umr*) = “age” — this is **Arabic's ʿumr**, borrowed into Hindi through Persian, and it's the everyday, colloquial word most Hindi speakers use. Hindi also has a fully **native Sanskrit** alternative, आयु (*āyu*, “age, lifespan”), which feels more formal or literary — a register split you've now seen several times (compare Kannada's Sanskrit-tatsama *madhyāhna* vs. Tamil's native words for the same concepts, just flipped here: the **borrowed** word is the everyday one, the **native** word is the formal one).

Your turn

- *Say it:* “umr” — age, same word as Arabic's ʿumr
- *Contrast:* everyday *umr* · formal/literary *āyu*

Before you move on

What language does Hindi's उम्र come from, and what's the native Sanskrit alternative? (**Arabic** *ʿumr*, via Persian; native alternative is आयु, *āyu*.) Which one is ordinary conversational Hindi? (**Umr**.) Next: use a genitive marker to say how many years someone belongs to.

19.2 कितने साल के हो? — belonging to so many years

Languages do not agree on whether age is something you have, are, were born with, or state without a verb. Hindi gives the idea a fifth shape.

You'll want to know — The two sentences

तुम कितने साल के हो? — “How old are you?” (informal), literally “you, of how many years, are?” (*tum kitne sāl ke ho?*)

मैं बीस साल का हूँ। — “I am twenty years old,” literally “I [am one] belonging to twenty years.” (*main̄ bīs sāl kā hūn̄*.)

के/का (*ke/kā*) is Hindi's **genitive postposition**, “of, belonging to.” The same marker family handles possession elsewhere: *merā ghar*, “my house.”

So Hindi does not copy Romance's “I **have** years,” Germanic's simple “I **am** [a number],” Latin's “**born** + N years,” or Arabic's verbless “my age [is] N.” It says “I am [one] **belonging to** N years,” with a genitive marker plus होना (*honā*, “to be”).

Your turn

- *Say it*: “tūm kitne sāl ke ho?” — how old are you?
- *Say it*: “main̄ bīs sāl kā hūn̄” — I belong to twenty years
- *Point to*: **ke/kā** — the genitive, “of/belonging to”

Before you move on

What does के/का mark? (A **genitive/possessive** relationship.) Does Hindi use Romance “have,” simple Germanic “be,” Latin “born,” or

Chapter 26

Night

By the end of this chapter: I can say night in Hindi and explain why रात and Latin’s *nox* are not cousins at all.

Trace rātri → ratti → raat, then state the honest twist: unlike दिन and diēs, रात and nox share no root.

26.1 रात (raat) — “night,” and an honest false cousin of Latin’s *nox*

Last lesson, *din* turned out to be a real (if distant) cousin of Latin’s *diēs*. This lesson is the mirror image: *raat* looks like it should be *nox*’s cousin too — but it genuinely isn’t.

You’ll want to know — रात — “night”

रात (*raat*) — “night” — is the word already hiding inside आधी रात (*ādhī rāt*, “midnight,” Chapter 17). It comes down through a completely ordinary sound-change chain: **Sanskrit** रात्रि (*rātri*) → **Prakrit** रत्ति (*ratti*, consonant cluster simplifying) → Hindi रात (*raat*) — the same shape of erosion you’ve already seen in Hindi’s numbers (*saptá* → *sāt*, *aṣṭá* → *āṭh*).

You’ll want to know — A genuine false cousin — not a true cognate

Here’s the honest twist: रात्रि (*rātri*) traces to **Proto-Indo- Iranian** **HráHtriH*, from **Proto-Indo-European** **h₁reh₁-trih₂* — built from a root meaning “to rest, remain still,” plus a feminine suffix. This is a

completely different PIE root from Latin’s **nox** (from **nók^wts*, the root behind English “night” itself, German *Nacht*, Greek *nyx*). Both *rātri* and *nox* are genuine Indo-European “night” words, in related language branches — but they are **not** cousins. Unlike *din* and *diēs* last lesson, which really do share one ancestor, *raat* and *nox* just happen to both mean “night,” from two entirely separate ancient roots. Sanskrit actually **does** keep a true *nók^wts* cousin of its own — नक्तम् (*naktam*, “by night”) — but it’s an archaic, adverbial word; it’s *rātri*, not *naktam*, that won the job of everyday Hindi’s *raat*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “raat” — “night,” already met inside ādhī rāt
- the sound chain — *rātri* → *ratti* → *raat*, the same erosion pattern as *saptá* → *sāt*
- the honest twist — *raat* and *nox* are NOT cousins, unlike *din* and *diēs*

Before you move on

Where have you already met रात before this lesson? (आधी रात, *ādhī rāt*, “midnight.”) What Sanskrit word, and what sound-change chain, gives Hindi **raat**? (रात्रि *rātri* → Prakrit *ratti* → *raat*.) Are *raat* and Latin’s *nox* true cognates, the way *din* and *diēs* are? (**No** — genuinely different PIE roots, **h₁reh₁-* “to rest” vs. **nók^wts* — a false cousin, despite both meaning “night.”)

Chapter 27

Good Night

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good night in Hindi and say why the phrase uses literary रात्रि rather than everyday रात.

Say शुभ रात्रि at parting, name the raat / rātri register pair, and trace śubh from 'to shine' to 'auspicious'.

27.1 शुभ रात्रि (śubh rātri) — “good night,” the formal doublet in action

Hindi keeps two versions of “night” side by side — one for everyday speech, one for set phrases. Here’s where the formal one gets used.

You’ll want to know — शुभ रात्रि — “auspicious night”

शुभ रात्रि (śubh rātri) — “good night” — literally “auspicious night.” Notice: this uses रात्रि (rātri), the very Sanskrit word last lesson’s raat descended **from** — but here, kept in its **full, unworn Sanskrit** form. This is a classic **tatsama/tadbhava doublet**: rātri (tatsama, a direct, unchanged Sanskrit borrowing) sits alongside raat (tadbhava, the same word worn down by centuries of ordinary sound change) — Hindi keeps both, one for everyday speech, one for set formal phrases like this one.

You’ll want to know — शुभ — “auspicious,” from a root meaning “to shine”

शुभ (śubh) — “auspicious, good, fortunate” — comes from the Sanskrit verbal root शुभ् (śubh), whose core sense is “to be beautiful, splendid.”

This traces to a well-sourced **Proto-Indo-European** root, **kewb^h-* (“to be beautiful”). Some scholars propose a **further, more speculative** connection beyond that — to **(s)kewh₁-* (“to perceive”) or **kew-* (“to shine”) — but that deeper link, not the **kewb^h-* root itself, is the genuinely uncertain part. Either way, the underlying idea is a familiar one: **auspiciousness imagined as a kind of radiance or beauty** — something good “shines.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubh rātri” — “good night,” literally “auspicious night”
- the formal doublet — rātri here, raat in everyday speech
- śubh’s own root — śubh, “to shine” → “auspicious”

Before you move on

Does शुभ रात्रि use the everyday *raat* or the formal *rātri*? (**The formal *rātri*** — Hindi keeps both versions, one for everyday speech, one for set phrases.) What does शुभ literally trace back to? (A root meaning “**to be beautiful, splendid,**” PIE **kewb^h-* — auspiciousness as a kind of radiance.) Is that root itself uncertain, or is a *further* proposed connection the shakier part? (**The root **kewb^h-* itself is well-sourced** — it’s the *deeper* proposed link, to “to shine” or “to perceive,” that’s genuinely speculative.)

Chapter 28

Morning

By the end of this chapter: I can say morning in Hindi and recognise सुबह as a Persian-Arabic loan rather than a Sanskrit word.

Say सुबह, find the ṣ-b-ḥ root it shares with Arabic ṣabāḥ, and name the break from Sanskrit दिन and रात.

28.1 सुबह (subah) — “morning,” and a root that also sits in Arabic

दिन and रात were both Sanskrit words, straight through. This one breaks that pattern completely — and lands on a root that also sits inside a different language entirely.

You’ll want to know — सुबह — a real surprise: not Sanskrit at all

सुबह (subah) — “morning” — is Hindi’s everyday, ordinary word for morning. Unlike दिन (*din*) and रात (*raat*, both Sanskrit tatsama, met the last two lessons), *subah* is genuinely **borrowed**: from **Persian** صبح (*subh*), itself from **Arabic** صبح (*ṣubḥ*), built on the Arabic trilateral root ح-ب-ص (*ṣ-b-ḥ*, “dawn, to become morning”).

You’ll want to know — A root that also sits inside an Arabic goodnight

Here’s the honest connection: this is the **exact same** Arabic root that sits inside the Arabic goodnight خیر علی تصبّح (*tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr*, “good night,” literally “may **you wake into goodness**,” built on this very root). Hindi’s

everyday word for “morning” and Arabic’s own good-night farewell — a phrase that never even mentions “night” — both trace to the **same three Arabic consonants**, ح-ب-ص, arriving in Hindi by a completely different route (via Persian) than they did staying in Arabic.

You’ll want to know — Be honest: *din* and *raat* didn’t prepare you for this

Don’t assume every Hindi time-word will be Sanskrit just because *din* and *raat* were. *Subah* is a genuine break in the pattern — a reminder that “everyday Hindi word” and “Sanskrit tatsama” aren’t the same category, even when the last two examples made it look that way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “subah” — “morning,” genuinely a Persian/Arabic loan
- the shared root — ṣ-b-ḥ, the same three consonants inside Arabic’s *tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr*
- the honest break — unlike *din* and *raat*, *subah* is NOT Sanskrit

Before you move on

Is सुबह a Sanskrit tatsama, like दिन and रात? (**No** — a genuine Persian/Arabic loanword.) Which Arabic phrase, met earlier in this lesson, shares सुबह’s exact root? (خير على تصبح, *tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr*, “good night” — both trace to the Arabic root ح-ب-ص, ṣ-b-ḥ.)

Chapter 29

Evening

By the end of this chapter: I can say evening in Hindi and refuse the tempting but false link between शाम and Sanskrit śyāmā.

Say शाम, reject the śyāmā resemblance as a false cognate, and pair it with सुबह as two loans from the same source.

29.1 शाम (shaam) — “evening,” and a tempting false cognate

Last lesson’s सुबह was Persian, not Sanskrit. This word is the same story — but this time there’s a Sanskrit look-alike close enough to trip you up on purpose.

You’ll want to know — शाम — Persian again, not Sanskrit

शाम (shaam) — “evening” — is, like *subah*, a genuine **Persian** loan-word: from Persian شام (*šām*), which traces back through **Proto-Iranian** **xšáfnyah* to **Proto-Indo-Iranian** **kšápā* (“night”). Hindi’s two everyday time-words for “morning” and “evening” both entered the language **via Persian**, not Sanskrit — though their deeper roots differ: *subah*’s traces further back to **Arabic**, while *shaam*’s is native **Indo-Iranian**, a sister branch to Sanskrit itself. Persian is what they share directly; their ultimate origins are not the same.

You'll want to know — Be careful: a tempting, but FALSE, cognate

Here's the trap: Sanskrit has its own word, श्यामा (*śyāmā*, “dark, night-colored”), that *looks* like it should be *shaam*'s cousin — similar sound, overlapping “darkness/night” meaning, right in the neighborhood you'd expect. It **isn't**. *Shaam* and *śyāmā* trace to **two completely separate roots** that simply converged on similar sounds and meanings by coincidence — a genuine **false cognate**, not a shared one. Don't let the resemblance fool you into inventing a connection that isn't there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “shaam” — “evening,” another genuine Persian loan
- the tempting trap — Sanskrit *śyāmā* looks related but ISN'T
- subah and shaam — both Persian, Hindi's whole “morning and evening” pair borrowed from the same source language

Before you move on

Is शाम Sanskrit or Persian? (**Persian** — from *شام*, *śām*, like *subah*.) Is शाम related to Sanskrit श्यामा (*śyāmā*, “dark”)? (**No** — a genuine false cognate; the resemblance is coincidental, not a shared root.) What do *subah* and *shaam* have in common, beyond both meaning a time of day? (**Both are Persian loanwords** — Hindi's morning/evening pair, unlike *din/raat*, isn't Sanskrit at all.)

Chapter 30

Afternoon

By the end of this chapter: I can say afternoon in Hindi using दोपहर in its modern, widened sense.

Say दोपहर में for 'in the afternoon' — the Chapter 17 word doing a wider job than its etymology promises.

30.1 दोपहर — the same word, a wider job than its etymology promised

You already know दोपहर means “noon” — two pahars after sunrise, precisely. This lesson’s honest twist is that the word doesn’t stay that precise in everyday use.

You’ll want to know — दोपहर — same word, a broader modern meaning

दोपहर (**dopahar**) is the exact word you met in Chapter 17, still literally “**two pahars**” (traditional ~3-hour watches, counted from sunrise) — but in **modern, everyday Hindi**, it no longer points only at that precise midday instant. Say दोपहर में (*dopahar mein*, “in the dopahar”) to arrange a meeting, and you’re pointing at a stretch of time — roughly **noon through late afternoon** — not a single moment. The historical etymology gave the word a very specific target (the end of the second daytime *pahar*); everyday usage has since widened that target into the general block of time most languages call “the afternoon.”

You'll want to know — Be honest: etymology and modern meaning have drifted apart

This is worth sitting with: दोपहर's **literal** story still holds up the way Chapter 17 described it — “two pahars,” with noon falling around the end of the second — though, as that lesson itself noted, treat the exact pahar-count as the general shape of the story rather than a precisely dated fact. Either way, the **word's job** in the language has moved on well past that etymology. This kind of drift — a word for one precise instant loosening into a name for a whole surrounding stretch of time — isn't unique to Hindi, but here it's especially visible because Chapter 17 showed you exactly how tight the original math was.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dopahar” — the same word from Chapter 17, “two pahars”
- “dopahar mein” — “in the afternoon,” a modern, widened usage
- the honest twist — the etymology stayed precise; the word's actual job widened past it

Before you move on

Is दोपहर a new word, or the same one from Chapter 17? (**The same word** — “two pahars.”) Does modern Hindi use दोपहर to mean only the exact instant of noon? (**No** — it's widened to cover the whole afternoon, roughly noon through late afternoon.) Has दोपहर's etymology itself changed to match this wider modern use? (**No** — the etymology still points precisely at noon; only the word's everyday job has widened.)

Chapter 31

Good Morning

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good morning in Hindi and judge when सुप्रभात fits and when नमस्ते is the better choice.

Say सुप्रभात, split it into su + prabhāt, and set that native Sanskrit dawn against the Persian loan सुबह.

31.1 सुप्रभात (suprabhāt) — “good morning,” a different root than the noun

सुबह was Persian, borrowed whole. This lesson’s “good morning” isn’t built on it at all — it reaches for entirely different, native vocabulary.

The two words — सुप्रभात

सुप्रभात (suprabhāt) — “good morning” — is built from सु (*su*, “good”) plus प्रभात (*prabhāta*, “dawn, daybreak”) — and *prabhāta* is **native Sanskrit**, from प्रभा (*prabhā*, “light, splendour”), itself from the root भा (“to shine”) plus the preverb प्र- (“forth”), plus the suffix -त (-*ta*). This is a **completely different word** from सुबह (*subah*, HI-C28), the Persian/Arabic loan you use for the everyday noun “morning.” Hindi’s “morning” and “good morning” don’t share a root at all.

The exchange — Formal register

Here’s a genuine, checked-not-assumed finding — hedged carefully, because the evidence behind it is thin: some sources describe Telugu speakers often code-switching to English “good night” instead of their own Sanskrit-

descended phrase, though that claim might apply more broadly across South Asian languages, not just Telugu. सुप्रभात's own story is different again, and just as worth hedging: it skews toward **formal, written** contexts — speeches, radio, the well-known Hindi WhatsApp-forward “good morning image” culture — rather than casual spoken conversation, where नमस्ते commonly covers mornings too. That's a real formal/everyday split, but it isn't the same thing as being displaced by **English** specifically — there's no strong evidence for that particular substitution here. Don't assume every “good ____” greeting in every language follows the same displacement story; verify each one on its own, and don't flatten a hedge into a fact either way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “suprabhāt” — “good morning,” su + prabhāt
- the root contrast — subah is Persian, prabhāt is native Sanskrit — completely different words
- the honest note — suprabhāt skews formal/written; नमस्ते covers casual mornings; no strong evidence of English displacement

Before you move on

Does सुप्रभात share a root with सुबह? (**No** — सुबह is Persian/Arabic; प्रभात, inside suprabhāt, is native Sanskrit, ultimately from भा, “to shine.”) Is सुप्रभात commonly used in casual spoken Hindi? (**Not especially** — it skews formal/written, with नमस्ते commonly covering mornings in everyday speech.) Is it being displaced by English “good morning,” the way some sources (thinly) suggested for other languages' night greetings? (**No strong evidence of that** — its own story is a formal/everyday split, not an English substitution.)

Chapter 32

Good Evening

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good evening in Hindi and choose between शुभ संध्या and नमस्ते by register.

Pick शुभ संध्या for a written evening card and नमस्ते for a casual 7 p.m. hello, treating the split as a tendency, not a ban.

32.1 शुभ संध्या (shubh sandhyā) — “good evening,” a twilight word with two lives

शाम was Persian. This greeting reaches for something else again — a native Sanskrit word for the exact moment day and night meet.

You’ll want to know — संध्या — “the junction of day and night”

संध्या (sandhyā) — “evening, twilight” — is **native Sanskrit**, from सम् (sam-, “together”) + धा (dhā, “to hold, to place”), literally “**holding together**” — the **junction** where day and night meet. This is a genuinely different word from शाम (shaam, HI-C29’s Persian loan): Hindi’s everyday evening noun and its “good evening” greeting don’t share a root, the same pattern already found for morning.

You’ll want to know — साँझ — a doublet, but not a simple “casual” version

संध्या has its own Hindi **tadbhava** doublet, साँझ (sāñjh), worn down through Prakrit the same way रात्रि became रात (HI-C26/27). But be careful not to force that exact parallel: unlike *rātri/raat*, where the tadbhava form clearly

became the everyday word and the tatsama stayed formal, sources describe साँझ as used across **both** literary/poetic **and** everyday communication — not simply “the casual one.” The doublet exists; the clean formal/casual split doesn’t carry over as neatly this time.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “shubh sandhyā” — “good evening,” su + sandhyā
- *Say it:* sandhyā’s own meaning — “holding together,” the junction of day and night
- *Contrast:* tatsama sandhyā · evolved doublet sāñjh

Before you move on

What does संध्या literally mean, and what is it built from? (“**Holding together**” — सम् + धा — i.e. the junction of day and night.) Does साँझ work the same way रात्रि/रात’s tatsama/tadbhava split did — one strictly formal, one strictly casual? (**No** — साँझ is used across both literary and everyday registers, not confined to one.) Next: choose between the written greeting and the casual all-day greeting.

32.2 शुभ संध्या or नमस्ते? — choose by setting

Shubh sandhyā is structurally transparent. The final question is where Hindi speakers actually reach for it.

You’ll want to know — Written warmth and casual speech

Like सुप्रभात, शुभ संध्या appears heavily in **written and social greeting-card culture**: greeting poetry, WhatsApp messages, and evening well-wishes. It is less likely to open an ordinary mid-conversation exchange.

नमस्ते works at any time of day, evenings included, and is more common in casual conversation than either *shubh prabhāt* or *shubh sandhyā*. The native language has divided the jobs: a Sanskrit “good _____” phrase for formal or written warmth, and another native greeting for everyday speech.

This is not English displacing a Hindi greeting. It is Hindi choosing between two of its own expressions by register and medium.

Your turn

- *Choose:* a WhatsApp evening card → शुभ संध्या
- *Choose:* greeting someone casually at 7 p.m. → नमस्ते
- *Say it:* “formal/written is a tendency, not an absolute ban”

Before you move on

Where does शुभ संध्या especially thrive? (**Written and social greeting-card culture.**) Does नमस्ते genuinely work in the evening? (**Yes** — it works at any time and is common casually.) Is the distinction Hindi versus English? (**No** — it is a native register/medium choice.)

Chapter 33

Good Afternoon

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good afternoon in Hindi and say honestly how rarely शुभ दोपहर is actually used.

Say शुभ दोपहर with दोपहर in its widened sense, then rank it honestly below नमस्ते/नमस्कार for everyday afternoons.

33.1 शुभ दोपहर (shubh dopahar) — “good afternoon,” this arc’s rarest greeting

You already know दोपहर’s meaning widened from “precisely noon” to “the afternoon.” This greeting rides that widened sense — but it’s the least commonly heard of the three you’ve now met.

You’ll want to know — शुभ दोपहर — “good afternoon,” using the widened sense

शुभ दोपहर (shubh dopahar) — “good afternoon” — pairs शुभ (“good”) with दोपहर used in the **widened, modern sense** from last lesson: “the afternoon” generally, not the narrow etymological “exactly noon.” Good news for consistency: this greeting confirms दोपहर’s widened meaning is the one people actually reach for here — nobody uses शुभ दोपहर to mean “good [precise instant of] noon.”

You'll want to know — Be honest: the rarest of the three, not just another formal phrase

Here's the twist this lesson adds, verified independently rather than assumed from सुप्रभात or शुभ संध्या's pattern: of this arc's three शुभ+timeword greetings, शुभ दोपहर is **described as the rarest** in actual spoken use — even more so than the other two. Sources call it formal/written, note that casual alternatives like आपका दोपहर शुभ हो (“may your afternoon be good”) exist but are themselves still uncommon, and confirm नमस्ते/नमस्कार do the real everyday greeting work across the whole afternoon, same as for morning and evening. This isn't just “another formal Sanskrit-style greeting” — it's the weakest-attested of the three, a genuine difference in **degree**, not just the same story repeated a third time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “shubh dopahar” — “good afternoon,” using दोपहर's widened modern sense
- the honest ranking — of सुप्रभात, शुभ संध्या, and शुभ दोपहर, this one is the rarest in actual spoken use
- नमस्ते/नमस्कार — the real everyday greeting, covering afternoons too

Before you move on

Does शुभ दोपहर use दोपहर's narrow “noon” sense or its widened “afternoon” sense? (**The widened sense** — “good afternoon,” not “good [exact] noon.”) Is शुभ दोपहर the most, or least, commonly used of this arc's three शुभ+timeword greetings? (**Least** — described as the rarest of the three in actual spoken use.) What covers the real everyday afternoon greeting instead? (नमस्ते/नमस्कार.)

Chapter 34

Four Verbs of the Mind

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I think, understand, read and write in Hindi, run all four through the present habitual, and say “Sorry, I don’t understand” when I need to.

Run सोचना, समझना, पढ़ना and लिखना through मैं ...ता/ती हूँ, spell out मेरा नाम from the letters you first wrote by hand, and name the one meaning — to scratch — that four unrelated families each chose for “write”.

34.1 सोचना (sochnā) — “to think,” and it used to mean “to grieve”

You can already run a Hindi verb: strip the -ना, keep the stem, add -ता/-ती/-ते and होना. Here is a verb worth running that machine on, because its history is a small shock.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

सोचना (sochnā) = “to think.” It behaves itself completely: the infinitive ends in -ना like every Hindi verb, and the stem is सोच- (soch-). So मैं सोचता हूँ (mairi sochtā hūmī, m.) / मैं सोचती हूँ (sochtī, f.) — “I think.” Respectfully, आप सोचते हैं (āp sochte haiṁ).

The stem is also a noun on its own. सोच (soch) means “a thought” — and, just as ordinarily, “worry.” Hold on to that double meaning; the word’s history is the reason for it.

You’ll want to know — thinking that started out as grieving

सोचना comes down from Sanskrit शोचति (śocati) — “burns; grieves; mourns” — on the root शुच् (śuc-). Through Prakrit the sound softened

and the sense drifted: *burn* → *be consumed by something* → *brood on it* → plain *think*. Hindi’s ordinary word for thinking is an old word for sorrow that cooled down.

Be honest about the limits: शुच् has **no secure English cousin**. Nothing *think*-shaped waits at the other end of this trail, and inventing one would be worse than saying so.

What travels instead is the **shape** of the change. English **think** and **thank** are one Germanic root — to thank someone was to *think well of* them. Latin **pēnsāre** meant “**to weigh**,” which is why English has **pensive**. Three unrelated families, three mind-verbs, not one of them starting out meaning “to think.”

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *mairi sochtā hūmī* · (f.): *mairi sochtī hūmī*]
- *Say it*: “you (resp.) think” — *āp sochte haiṁī*
- *Say it*: *nahīmī* on its own, then slide it in front of the verb — *mairi nahīmī sochtā / sochtī*, “I don’t think so.” Hindi’s negator sits **before** the verb, never after it
- *Say it*: the noun *soch*, and both things it means — a thought, and a worry

Before you move on

What did *śocatī* mean before it meant “think”? (**To burn, to grieve.**) Which everyday Hindi noun still carries both halves, and where does *nahīmī* sit in *mairi nahīmī sochtā*? (सोच, a thought *and* a worry; *nahīmī* goes **before the verb**.) Is there an English cousin of *śuc-*? (**No.**)

34.2 समझना (samajhnā) — “to understand,” which is to say “to wake up”

Sochnā got you thinking. This verb gets you the single most useful sentence a beginner owns — the one you say when you have **not** understood.

The letters in this word

स (sa) + म (ma) → सम; then झ (jha), the breathy pair of ja; then ना (nā). Read स · म · झ · ना → *samajhnā*. The झ is one puff of air heavier than a plain j, the same aspiration that separates Hindi's k from its kh.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

समझना (*samajhnā*) = “to understand.” Stem समझ-, so मैं समझता हूँ (m.) / मैं समझती हूँ (f.), and respectfully आप समझते हैं.

Like *soch*, the bare stem is a noun: समझ (*samajh*) is “understanding, sense, judgement.”

And the sentence to bank tonight: मैं नहीं समझता / समझती — “I don't understand.” Put माफ़ कीजिए in front of it and you have a complete, polite repair: *māf kījiye, maini nahīni samajhtā* — “Sorry, I don't understand.” Every word of that you already had.

You'll want to know — the root that gave the Buddha his name

The standard derivation takes समझना back to Sanskrit सम् (*sam-*, “fully, together”) + the root बुध् (*budh-*, “to wake, to become aware”). Older Hindi still says समुझना (*samujhnā*), and that surviving -u- is the fingerprint of *budh-* before it wore down.

So you already know this root in English, twice over, because English took the words whole:

- बुद्ध (*buddha*) — “the one who woke up.” English **Buddha**.
- बोधि (*bodhi*) — the awakening itself; and बुद्धि (*buddhi*), intellect.

Further back, *budh-* rests on the reconstructed root *bheudh-*, and its Germanic branch surfaces in English **bode**, **forebode** and **forbid** (*for-* + “announce”). Hindi's “I understand,” then, is a claim to have woken up — and the Buddha's title is the same claim, made once and for all.

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *maini samajhtā hūni* · (f.): *maini samajhtī hūmī*]
- Say it: the repair, slowly — *māf kījiye, maini nahīni samajhtā / samajhtī*

- Say it: *māim sochtā hūm* then *māim samajhtā hūm* — thinking, then getting it
- Say it: *buddha* and *bodhi*, and what *budh-* means underneath them (to wake)

Before you move on

What are the two pieces inside *samajhnā*? (सम् “fully” + बुध् “to wake.”) Say “Sorry, I don’t understand.” (*Māf kījiye, māim nahīm samajhtā / samajhtā.*) Which famous title is built on the same root, and what does it mean? (**Buddha** — “the one who woke up.”)

34.3 पढ़ना (*paṛhnā*) — “to read,” and just as often “to study”

One verb, two English words. And one letter you have never had to say out loud before.

The letters in this word

प (*pa*), then ढ, then ना (*nā*) → प · ढ · ना.

That middle letter is ढ (*dha*) wearing the **nuqtā** — the same small dot you met under फ़ in *māf*, Hindi’s mark for a sound the plain letter cannot carry. Dotted, ढ becomes a **flap**: curl the tongue back to the roof of the mouth and let it snap forward, with a breath behind it. That is **ṛh**. The word is *paṛhnā*, not *padhna*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पढ़ना (*paṛhnā*) = “to read” — and, with no change at all, “to study.”

Stem पढ़-: मैं पढ़ता हूँ (m.) / मैं पढ़ती हूँ (f.); आप पढ़ते हैं.

Two words grow straight off that stem, and both are everywhere in Indian life: पढ़ाई (*paṛhāī*) = “studies, schooling,” and पढ़ाना (*paṛhānā*) = “to teach” — literally “to cause to read.”

You’ll want to know — reading, when reading meant reciting

The ancestor is Sanskrit पठति (*paṭhati*) — “recites; reads aloud.” Not *scans a page*. Sanskrit’s name for its oldest texts is श्रुति (*śruti*), “that

which is heard”: the Veda was memorised and spoken, and to “read” it was to say it. That is why one Hindi verb still covers reading and studying — for centuries they were the same act.

The sound wore down on the ordinary road: *paṭhati* → Prakrit *paḍhai* → *paṛhnā*, the hard **ṭh** loosening between two vowels into the flap you just made.

And the honest note: **paṭh-** has no secure Indo-European ancestry. No English cousin, and possibly not an inherited Indo-Aryan word at all. Where the trail stops, this book stops with it.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the flap alone — *ṛh*, *ṛh* — then the whole word, *paṛhnā*
- [YOU SAY (m.): *maini paṛhtā hūmi* · (f.): *maini paṛhtī hūmi* — and mean both “I read” and “I study”]
- *Say it*: do what the verb originally meant — recite एक, दो, तीन, चार, पाँच, छह, सात, आठ, नौ, दस aloud, one to ten, then say *maini paṛhtā hūmi*
- *Say it*: *maini paṛhtā hūmi*, then *maini samajhtā hūmi* — read it, then get it

Before you move on

What two English verbs does *paṛhnā* cover? (**Read** and **study**.)
 What did *paṭhati* mean, and why does that explain the pair? (**To recite aloud** — reading was saying.) Recite one to five in Hindi from memory. (*Ek, do, tīn, chār, pāñch.*)

34.4 लिखना (likhnā) — “to write,” which everywhere means “to scratch”

Reading has its verb. Here is the other half — and the chapter’s four mind-verbs come back together at the end of it.

The letters in this word

ल (*la*) with the short ि → लि (*li*); then ख (*kha*); then ना (*nā*) → लि · ख · ना.

The ि is the one that runs ahead of itself: it is drawn to the **left** of ल but sounded **after** it, exactly as in हिंदी. Devanagari writes the mark first and your mouth says it second — *li*, never *il*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

लिखना (*likhnā*) = “**to write**.” Stem लिख-: मैं लिखता हूँ (m.) / मैं लिखती हूँ (f.); आप लिखते हैं.

Its Sanskrit ancestor is लिखति (*likhati*), and *likhati*’s first meaning is not “writes” at all. It is “**scratches, scrapes, furrows**.” Writing entered the verb afterwards, once there was something to scratch a mark into.

You’ll want to know — five families, one picture

Now the striking part. Ask what “write” meant before it meant writing, and the same answer comes back from languages that never borrowed it from each other:

- Sanskrit लिखति — to **scratch**.
- Latin **scribere** — to **incise, cut**. English took **scribe, script, describe, manuscript** from it.
- Greek **gráphein** — to **scratch, carve**; behind **graph** and every **-graphy**. It is genuinely cousin to English **carve**.
- Old English **writan** — to **score, cut**; that is English **write** itself.

These are **four different roots**, not one worn four ways. Nobody handed this metaphor around. Four peoples with wax, stone, bark and bone each looked at their sharp tool and named the act after the damage it did. Hindi’s verb is one of them, and it kept the older sense honestly enough that *likhati* still glosses as “scrapes.”

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *mairi likhtā hūmī* · (f.): *mairi likhtī hūmī*]
- *Say it*: the chapter in one breath — *mairi sochtā hūmī*, *mairi samajhtā hūmī*, *mairi parhtā hūmī*, *mairi likhtā hūmī*; then the same four as a woman, in *-tī*

- *Say it:* spell out मेरा नाम, the two words you first assembled by hand — म, the *e*-mātrā above it, र, the ā-tail; then न, ā, म — and finish with *maini likhtā hūni*
- *Say it:* *likhati*, *scribere*, *gráphein*, *writan* — and the one meaning all four started from (to scratch)

Before you move on

What did *likhati* mean first? (**To scratch.**) Are Sanskrit *likh-*, Latin *scribere* and English *write* one root or four? (**Four** — the picture is shared, the word is not.) Run the chapter's four verbs in the *maini ... hūni* frame. (*Sochtā, samajhtā, paṛhtā, likhtā.*)

Chapter 35

Taking, Asking, Helping — and Liking

By the end of this chapter: I can say I take, ask and help in Hindi, build a conjunct verb out of any noun plus करना, and say what I like the way Hindi says it — with the thing liked as the subject and me in the dative.

Say लेना, पूछना and मदद करना, then turn the sentence inside out: मुझे रोटी पसंद है is bread being pleasing to me, so है agrees with the bread and I move into मुझे — the same inversion Spanish and Italian reached on their own.

35.1 लेना (lenā) — “to take,” a verb that lost a consonant

Four verbs of the mind are behind you. This chapter puts your hands back in the world — starting with the shortest verb in it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

लेना (lenā) = “to take.” Two syllables, and one of the most-used verbs in the language. Stem ले-: मैं लेता हूँ (m.) / मैं लेती हूँ (f.); आप लेते हैं. It reaches further than English “take”. Offered a drink, a Hindi speaker answers मैं पानी लेता हूँ — “I’ll have water,” the same lenā. It pairs with its opposite in the fixed phrase लेन-देन (len-den), “taking and giving” — Hindi’s word for dealings, transactions, business between people.

You’ll want to know — the consonant that fell out

लेना looks too short to have a history. It has a long one. Sanskrit’s verb was लभते (*labhate*) — “**takes, obtains, receives.**” Through Prakrit *lahai* the **-bh-** thinned to a breath and then vanished, and the two vowels left behind fused into the single ले- you now say. Almost the whole word eroded.

The proof is sitting in Hindi’s own vocabulary. लाभ (*lābh*) — “**profit, gain, benefit**” — was borrowed back from Sanskrit later, straight out of the books, so it never went through that erosion. Verb and noun are the same word at two different ages: one worn smooth by mouths, one preserved on the shelf.

Further out, the standard comparison lines *labh-* up with Greek **lam-bánein**, “to take” — and English quietly holds three of its descendants: a **syllable** is letters “taken together”; **epilepsy** is “a seizing upon”; so is **catalepsy**.

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *mairi letā hūmī* · (f.): *mairi letī hūmī*]
- *Say it:* accept a drink — *mairi pānī letā hūmī*; then a meal — *mairi roṭī letā hūmī*. Object first, verb last, as always
- *Say it:* *pānī* and what it literally means (the drinkable thing), then *roṭī*
- *Say it:* *lenā* and *lābh* one after the other — the same Sanskrit verb, worn down and preserved

Before you move on

Which Sanskrit verb is *lenā*, and which consonant did it lose? (लभते *labhate*; the **-bh-**.) Which Hindi noun still shows that consonant, and why? (लाभ — borrowed back from Sanskrit, so it never eroded.) Say “I’ll have water.” (*Mairi pānī letā / letī hūmī*.)

35.2 पूछना (pūchnā) — “to ask,” and the reason English says “pray”

You have been asking questions since chapter two. Here, at last, is the verb for doing it.

The letters in this word

प (*pa*) with the long ू hanging beneath it → पू (*pū*); then छ (*cha*), the breathy pair of *ca*; then ना (*nā*) → पू · छ · ना.

The *ū* is genuinely long, and छ takes a puff of air, one degree heavier than the च in *sochnā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पूछना (*pūchnā*) = “to ask,” in the sense of asking a **question**. Stem पूछ-: मैं पूछता हूँ (m.) / मैं पूछती हूँ (f.); आप पूछते हैं.
You already own a question — कितने साल के हो, “how many years are you of.” Now you can name the act itself: मैं उम्र पूछता हूँ, “I ask (someone’s) age.” The thing asked about sits in front of the verb, where every object has gone.

You’ll want to know — asking a person, asking a god

Behind पूछना stands Sanskrit पृच्छति (*pr̥cchati*, “asks”), and behind that a reconstructed root *prek-*, “to ask.” This one paid out generously across the family:

- Latin **precārī**, “to beg, to entreat” — English **pray**, **prayer**, **deprecate**, **imprecation**.
- Latin **precārius**, “held only so long as another allows” — English **precarious**. A precarious thing is one you keep by asking.
- German **fragen**, Dutch **vragen** — everyday “to ask” to this day.

English is the odd one out, instructively. Its own inherited cousin, Old English **frignan**, died out, and **ask** comes from somewhere else entirely — so the *prek-* word survived in English only in its religious clothes. Saying मैं पूछता हूँ, you use the verb English kept for **praying**, because asking a person and asking a god were once one act with one name.

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *maini pūchtā hūni* · (f.): *maini pūchtī hūmī*]
- *Say it*: the chapter-19 question, then name what you just did — *kitne sāl ke ho? ... maini umr pūchtā hūni*

- Say it: *māimī pūchtā hūmī*, then *māimī letā hūmī* — I ask, I take
- Say it: *pūchnā*, then **pray**, **precarious**, **fragen** — one root, three destinations

Before you move on

Which English verb is *pūchnā*'s true cousin — *ask* or *pray*? (**Pray** — *ask* is unrelated.) What does *precarious* literally describe? (Something **held only by asking**.) Say “I ask (someone's) age.” (*Māimī umr pūchtā / pūchtī hūmī*.)

35.3 मदद करना (madad karnā) — “to help,” and the machine that builds it

This one is not a verb. It is a noun with a verb attached — and once you spot the join, you can build hundreds more.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मदद (*madad*) is a **noun**: “**help, aid**.” On its own it does nothing. Bolt करना (*karnā*, “to do”) on the end and you have the verb: मदद करना, literally “**to do help**.”

Only करना ever conjugates. The noun sits still:

- मैं मदद करता हूँ (m.) / मैं मदद करती हूँ (f.) — “I help.”
- आप मदद करते हैं — “you (resp.) help.”

This is the **conjunct verb**, and you have already used two without being told: काम करना, “to do work” = to work; and माफ़ कीजिए, “please do forgiveness” = sorry. One join, three verbs.

You'll want to know — a stretched-out hand, and why the pattern matters

मदद is Arabic **madad**, on the root م-د-د (*m-d-d*), “**to stretch out, to extend**.” Help, in Arabic, is a thing **extended** toward you — the picture English reaches for when it *extends* a hand. It came into Hindi through **Persian**, the same road as उम्र (age) and माफ़ (forgiven).

State the gap plainly: English inherited **nothing** from *m-d-d*, and English **help** is a Germanic word unrelated to any of this. The picture is shared; the word is not.

Now why this matters more than one verb. A borrowed noun cannot be conjugated — Hindi would have to bend a foreign word through its own endings. With करना it never has to: the loan stays a frozen noun and native grammar does the work. That is how Hindi swallowed centuries of Persian and Arabic vocabulary without disturbing its verb system at all.

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *māim madad kartā hūmī* · (f.): *māim madad kartī hūmī*]
- *Say it*: the three joins in a row — *kām karnā, māf karnā, madad karnā*; hear that only the second word ever moves
- *Say it*: *māim pūchtā hūmī*, then *māim madad kartā hūmī* — I ask, I help
- *Say it*: what *m-d-d* means underneath *madad* (to stretch out, extend)

Before you move on

Which half of *madad karnā* takes the endings? (करना — the noun never changes.) Name two conjunct verbs you had already used. (काम करना; माफ़ कीजिए.) Why does this pattern let Hindi borrow so freely? (The loan **stays a noun**; native *karnā* carries the grammar.)

35.4 पसंद (pasand) — Hindi does not like things; things please Hindi

Every verb so far let you be the one doing something. This last one takes that away.

You'll want to know — मुझे, the shape of “to me”

मुझे (*mujhe*) = “to me.” It is what मैं (“I”) becomes when the sentence will not let you be its subject. *Mujhe* is not “I.”

Grammar Lens: the thing you like is the subject

मुझे रोटी पसंद है = “I like bread” — or, taken apart: मुझे (“to me”) + रोटी (“bread”) + पसंद (“pleasing”) + है (“is”). “To me, bread is pleasing.” रोटी is the **subject**, and that is what है agrees with. You are only the person it happens to. Hindi has no “I like bread” with *I* in front. Two languages walked here alone: Spanish **me gusta el café** (“to me, the coffee pleases”) and Italian **mi piace**. Those two are close cousins; Hindi is not, and nobody borrowed it. Two families, one decision — liking happens **to** you.

You’ll want to know — a Persian word doing a verb’s job

Because पसंद is **not a verb**. It is **Persian** — from پسندیدن (*pasandīdan*, “to approve, to find pleasing”) — and it entered Hindi as a noun and adjective, “**liked, one’s choice**.” A non-verb cannot carry the person doing the liking, so the grammar put them elsewhere: मुझे.

It came by the Persian road that also gave you शाम (evening) — and see what these two chapters have shown. Hindi’s verbs of the mind (*sochnā, samajhnā, parhnā, likhnā*) are inherited Indo-Aryan to a word, while *madad* and *pasand* — helping and liking — are borrowed. Thinking stayed home; the social vocabulary travelled.

For an active “like”, Hindi uses last lesson’s join: पसंद करना, “to do liking,” nearer to “I choose, I prefer.” For everyday liking, मुझे ... पसंद है.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mujhe rotī pasand hai*, then the Hindi meaning — “to me, bread is pleasing”
- swap the thing, leaving *mujhe ... pasand hai* untouched — *mujhe pānī pasand hai* · *mujhe kuttā pasand hai* · *mujhe shām pasand hai*
- the chapter end to end — *maimi letā hūmī, maimi pūchtā hūmī, maimi madad kartā hūmī, mujhe rotī pasand hai*
- *pasand karnā* beside *madad karnā* — one join, twice

Before you move on

In *mujhe rotī pasand hai*, what is the subject? (रोटी — which is why it is *hai*.) What part of speech is *pasand*, and from where? (A **noun/adjective**, from **Persian** — not a verb.) Say “I like the dog,” then what it literally means. (*Mujhe kuttā pasand hai* — “to me, dog is pleasing.”)

Chapter 36

One House, Four Languages

By the end of this chapter: I can name a house, its door, a room and the chair I am offered, give each one the possessive its gender demands, and say where each of the four words came from — Sanskrit, Persian, Portuguese and Arabic.

Run घर, दरवाज़ा, कमरा and कुर्सी with the right possessive — and hear मेरा turn into मेरी at the first feminine noun, the promise chapter 2 made and never kept. Then name the four languages one room drew on, spell कुर्सी with its virāma and its conjunct, and say नमस्ते at the door coming in and शुभ रात्रि going out.

36.1 घर (ghar) — “house,” and the fence that came first

You can say your name. Now say where you live — and meet the one thing every Hindi noun carries that English nouns do not.

The letters in this word

Two letters. घ (gha), the breathy pair of ga, then र (ra), already yours from मेरा.

र is the spineless one: no upright stroke of its own, so the शिरोरेखा, the head-line, is all that ties it to its neighbour. Both letters keep their inherent *a* → घर, ghar.

Grammar Lens: the word arrives with a gender

घर (ghar) = “house, home.” And it is **masculine**.

Every Hindi noun is masculine or feminine. Not the thing — the **word**.

There is nothing manly about a house; the gender is a fact about *ghar* the way its spelling is, and you learn the two together or you learn them twice.

It is not decoration: it changes the words around the noun. Because *ghar* is masculine, “my house” is मेरा घर (*merā ghar*), the masculine मेरा, exactly as in मेरा नाम.

Whole sentence: यह मेरा घर है (*yah merā ghar hai*), “this is my house.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

घर comes from Sanskrit गृह (*gr̥ha*), worn smooth through Prakrit *ghara* into the short word you just said. Hindi kept गृह too, borrowed back out of Sanskrit for formal use, so both shapes survive.

Further back, *gr̥ha* descends from an ancient root meaning **enclosure**, *gʰerdʰ-* — and English holds two plain descendants of it: **yard** and **garden**. Slavic holds the *-grad* in **Belgrade**, “town.”

So the oldest sense is not walls and a roof. It is **a fenced-in piece of ground**. You enclose the land first; the house is what goes inside afterwards.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ghar* — house; then *merā ghar*; then *yah merā ghar hai*
- *merā nām* and *merā ghar* one after the other — the same *merā*, because both nouns are masculine
- the two letters, *gha* and *ra*, and which of them has no spine
- *gr̥ha*, then *ghar* — the Sanskrit shape and the worn one; then the old meaning, *enclosure*

Before you move on

Is घर masculine or feminine, and how do you know from the sentence? (**Masculine** — *merā*, not *merī*.) What did the root behind *gr̥ha* mean before it meant a building? (**An enclosure** — the root behind *yard* and *garden*.) Which of घ and र hangs from the head-line without a spine of its own? (र.)

36.2 दरवाज़ा (darvāzā) — the door, and the oldest word you already know

You have a house. This is what you stand at to be let into one — and it is where नमस्ते is said and where शुभ रात्रि is said back.

The letters in this word

द • र • वा • ज़ा — and the ा you already write does two of the four.

The new mark is the dot under ज़: the **nuqta**. Plain ज is *ja*. Persian arrived carrying a **z** Devanagari had no letter for, so the script put a dot beneath the nearest shape and made one — ज़, *za*. The same dot makes फ़ (*fa*) and ख़, the sound in खुशी.

A nuqta is a small confession in ink: *this sound came from somewhere else*.

Grammar Lens: the shape that usually tells you

दरवाज़ा (*darvāzā*) = “door,” and it is **masculine** — so मेरा दरवाज़ा.

Here is your first piece of help. A noun ending in long **-ā** is usually masculine, and *darvāzā* ends in -ा. Keep it as a lean, not a law: later chapters will show you where it fails, in both directions.

घर ends in a consonant and is masculine too — so a consonant ending tells you nothing at all. That one you simply learn.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

दरवाज़ा is **Persian**, دروازه (*darvāza*), and its first syllable is where this gets remarkable. Persian در (*dar*) means “door,” and it descends from the ancient root *d^hwer-* — as do English **door**, Latin **forēs**, Greek **thúrā** and Sanskrit द्वार (*dvāra*).

Now the twist. Hindi *also* has द्वार (*dvār*), taken straight out of Sanskrit for formal use. So the borrowed Persian word and the learned Sanskrit one are **the same ancient word, arrived twice**, by two roads, centuries apart.

The **-vāza** part is less settled: usually connected to a Persian word for “open,” but disputed, and worth leaving open.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *darvāzā*, then *merā darvāzā*, then *merā ghar* — one *merā*, two masculine nouns
- the arrival and the leaving at the same door — *namaste* going in, *shubh rātri* going out
- *ja*, then *za* — the letter, then the letter with the dot
- *dar*, *door*, *thūrā*, *dvāra* — one word, four languages

Before you move on

What does the dot under ज्ञ tell you? (That the sound is **borrowed** — Devanagari had no *z*.) Persian *dar* and English *door* — coincidence or cousins? (**Cousins**, from *d^hwer-* — and Hindi's own द्वार is the third.) Which ending gives you a fair guess at masculine? (**Long -ā**, as in *darvāzā*. A consonant ending, as in *ghar*, tells you nothing.)

36.3 कमरा (*kamrā*) — the room that is also a camera

Through the door, and into this. A short, ordinary word — which travelled to India by sea, on Portuguese ships.

The letters in this word

क · म · रा — and म (*ma*) is one of the first two letters you ever wrote, beside न.

Both of those hang from the head-line and both stand on a right-hand spine; that upright is what your eye follows along a line of Devanagari. क and र you have as well, so this word costs you nothing new — only the ा riding on the final र.

Grammar Lens: the lean holds

कमरा (*kamrā*) = “**room**,” and it is **masculine** — मेरा कमरा.

Long **-ā**, masculine again, exactly as दरवाज़ा was. Three nouns in, and the possessive has not changed once: *merā ghar*, *merā darvāzā*, *merā kamrā*.

Hold on to that flatness. It is about to break.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कमरा is neither Sanskrit nor Persian. It is **Portuguese** — **câmara**, “chamber, room” — left behind on India’s western coast by the traders who ran that shore from the sixteenth century, along with चाबी (*chābī*, “key”) and अलमारी (*almārī*, “cupboard”).

Portuguese *câmara* is Latin **camera**, “a vaulted chamber,” and Latin took it from Greek **kamára** — where the trail honestly stops; the Greek word’s own origin is unknown.

Then the good part. English **camera** is that same Latin word: a *camera obscura* was literally a “dark room,” and when the dark room shrank into a box the name went with it. And Hindi later borrowed it back through English as कैमरा (*kaimrā*) for the device.

So कमरा and कैमरा are the *same Latin word*, arrived twice by two different routes — the second time carrying a machine that did not exist when the first one landed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kamrā*, then *merā kamrā*
- the three so far, in one breath — *merā ghar, merā darvāzā, merā kamrā*
- *kamrā* and *kaimrā* — one Latin word, two arrivals
- where each of the three came from — Sanskrit, Persian, Portuguese

Before you move on

Which language handed Hindi कमरा, and how did it get there? (**Portuguese**, by sea, on the western coast.) What does *kamrā* share with English *camera*? (**One Latin word**, *camera*, “vaulted chamber” — Hindi has it twice, as *kamrā* and *kaimrā*.) Say “my house, my door, my room.” (*Merā ghar, merā darvāzā, merā kamrā*.)

36.4 कुर्सी (kursī) — sit down, and watch मेरा change

House, door, room — and now what you are offered once inside.
This word breaks the pattern the other three set.

The letters in this word

कु · र · सी — three old letters, क, र, स, and two working marks.

क takes ु for *ku*. Then र with the **virāma**, the stroke that kills a consonant's built-in *a*: a bare र cannot stand alone, so it fuses with the स, and the hook above स *is* that र — the fusing you met in स्त.

Then सी: the long ी stands after its consonant and sounds after it, while ि stands before and still sounds after. One of the two lies to your eye.

Grammar Lens: your first feminine noun

कुर्सी (*kursī*) = “**chair**,” and it is **feminine**.

So मेरी कुर्सी, not *merā*. When you learnt मेरा you were told you would meet मेरी at your first feminine noun. Here it is.

Nothing about a chair is female. The gender belongs to the **word**, and it changes मेरा. Get it wrong and every word beside the noun goes wrong too.

Grammar Lens: the lean, and where it leans wrong

The rule of thumb: **long -ā tends masculine, long -ī tends feminine, a consonant ending tells you nothing**. A lean, not a law: *darvāzā*, *kamrā* and *kursī* obey it, *ghar* sits outside it, and later words will disobey it outright.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कुर्सी is **Arabic**, كرسي (*kursī*), “seat, throne,” reaching Hindi through **Persian**, the road most Arabic words took.

Arabic did not invent it either. It has passed along the Near East for four thousand years: Sumerian **guza**, Akkadian **kussû**, then Ugaritic, Hebrew and Aramaic, Arabic most likely taking it from **Aramaic**. Not one family — the word crossed between unrelated families because the object did.

English **chair**? Greek **kathédra**, through Latin and French. No relation at all.

And what this chapter has done: घर Sanskrit, दरवाज़ा Persian, कमरा Portuguese, कुर्सी Arabic. One room, four languages — that is Hindi, not an accident of these four words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *merī kursī*, then *merā kamrā* — one possessive, two shapes
- the chapter — *merā ghar*, *merā darvāzā*, *merā kamrā*, *merī kursī*
- each word's source — Sanskrit, Persian, Portuguese, Arabic
- *namaste* at the *darvāzā*, then *shubh rātri* at the same door

Before you move on

Why मेरी कुर्सी? (कुर्सी is **feminine**; the possessive agrees with the noun.) How far back does *kursī* go, and did it stay in one family? (**Sumerian** — and no, it crossed unrelated families.) Name the chapter's four sources. (**Sanskrit, Persian, Portuguese, Arabic.**)

Chapter 37

One Tea, Please

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for tea, milk, food or a book in the words Hindi speakers actually use rather than the dictionary's, I know that कृपया belongs on a sign and दीजिए in the street, and I can name which of the four nouns take मेरी.

Ask for all four — एक चाय दीजिए, एक दूध दीजिए, खाना दीजिए, and the किताब that is मेरी — then unpack the Arabic root k-t-b into book, scribe and school, and place कृपया where it belongs, beside पुस्तक at the formal end of the language.

37.1 चाय (chāy) — tea, and how to actually ask for one

You are in the chair, in the room Portuguese named. Somebody is about to offer you this — and by the end of these few minutes you will be able to ask for it yourself, in the words people actually use.

Grammar Lens: the lean fails, quietly

चाय (chāy) = “tea,” and it is **feminine**.

Nothing outside the word says so. It does not end in -ी the way कुर्सी does; it ends in a consonant, and the lean warned you a consonant ending tells you nothing. चाय is feminine and you simply learn it — now, with the word.

You'll want to know — how you really ask

एक चाय दीजिए (ek chāy dījie) — “one tea, please.”

दीजिए is “give” spoken to आप: the polite request form. That -िए ending is the politeness. Nothing else is needed.

Which means a correction. You learnt कृपया as “please,” and it is a real word — but it belongs to **signs, forms and station announcements**. Across a counter it lands like *kindly furnish me with tea*.

So: कृपया when you write, दीजिए when you speak. And you already have the shape — माफ़ कीजिए carries the very same -िए.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

चाय is **Chinese**. In most of China the word for the leaf is **chá**, which Persian took as چای (*chāy*) and handed to Hindi.

Now the English word: **tea**. French **thé**, Dutch **thee** — a different sound entirely, for the identical leaf.

They are the same word. China writes it with one character everywhere, but reads that character differently: in the Hokkien of the south-eastern coast it is **tê**, and Dutch ships bought their tea *there*.

The tempting story is overland versus sea. It is wrong: Portuguese say **chá**, and Portuguese tea came by sea. The variable is **which Chinese port a trader dealt with**. Your word for tea records a harbour.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *chāy*; then *ek chāy dījie*
- the same request for water — *ek pānī dījie*
- *dījie* and *māf kījie* one after the other — hear the shared *-ie*
- *chā* and *tê* — the two Chinese pronunciations, and which one English bought

Before you move on

Is चाय masculine or feminine, and does its ending help? (**Feminine** — and no, a consonant ending never does.) Where does कृपया belong, and what carries the politeness when you speak? (**Signs and announcements** — in speech the -िए of *dījie* does it.) Are *chāy* and *tea* related? (**The same Chinese word**, bought at two different ports.)

37.2 दूध (dūdh) — “milk,” which is really a verb wearing a noun’s coat

What goes into the tea. And it is named the same sly way पानी was — by what happens to it, not by what it is.

Grammar Lens: the pair that disagrees

दूध (*dūdh*) = “milk,” and it is **masculine**.

Which makes these two a useful pair, because they sit side by side in every cup and disagree: चाय feminine — the leaf that came by way of a Chinese port — and दूध masculine. Both end in consonants. Neither ending tells you anything. This is the ordinary state of a Hindi noun, and it is why the gender is part of the word, not an afterthought.

एक दूध दीजिए — same request, new noun.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

दूध comes from Sanskrit दुग्ध (*dugdha*) — and *dugdha* is not a noun at all. It is a **past participle** of the verb दुह् (*duh-*), “to milk.” It means “milked.”

So the substance is named for the act. Somebody said “the milked” often enough that the adjective hardened into a thing. You have seen this exact move already: पानी is *pānīya*, “the drinkable.” Hindi’s two commonest liquids are both named by what is done to them.

Behind *duh-* stands the old root *dʰewǵʰ-*, and its meaning is broader than milk: “to yield, to be strong, to be of use.” Greek *teúkhēin*, “to produce,” is from it, and so is English **doughty**, “stout, valiant.”

One trap, since the shape invites it: English **dough** is **not** related. It comes from a different root meaning “to knead, to form.” *Dūdh* and *dough* look like cousins and are strangers.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dūdh*; then *ek dūdh dījie*
- the disagreeing pair — *chāy* feminine, *dūdh* masculine
- what each one literally is — *dugdha*, “the milked”; *pānīya*, “the drinkable”

- *dūdh* and *dough* — and that they are not related

Before you move on

What part of speech was *dugdha* before it was milk? (**A past participle** — “milked.”) Which Hindi word plays the same trick, and how? (पानी — *pānīya*, “the drinkable thing.”) Is English *dough* a cousin of *dūdh*? (**No** — different root; *doughty* is the real one.)

37.3 खाना (*khānā*) — “food,” and the dot that separates it from a house

Drink is behind you. This is the general word for what you eat — and it has a twin on the page that means something else entirely.

The letters in this word

खा · ना — two syllables, and the ा does both.

ख (*kha*) takes ा → खा. Then न (*na*), your very first letter, takes ा → ना. The ा is the *mātrā* that replaces a consonant’s built-in *a* with a long one, exactly as in नाम.

Two consonants, one mark used twice, and the word is yours.

Grammar Lens: one word doing two jobs

खाना (*khānā*) = “food,” and it is **masculine** — long *-ā*, and this time the lean holds. Unlike दूध, whose name is a participle, this one is plainly a thing.

It is also the verb “**to eat**.” Same spelling, same sound: the infinitive doubles as a noun, the way English says *the eating was good*.

So खाना दीजिए is “give me food,” and खाना alone can be the act. Which one you mean, the sentence decides.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Both come from Sanskrit खाद् (*khād-*), “to eat” — the noun through खादन (*khādana*), “the act of eating, food,” and the verb through खादति (*khādati*), “eats.”

Now the twin. Hindi also has खाना (*khāna*) — with the **nuqta** under the first letter — and it is **Persian**, خانه (*xāna*), “house, compartment,

section.” You meet it inside दवाखाना (*davākhāna*), a “medicine-house”: a pharmacy.

Two unrelated words, one from Sanskrit and one from Persian, separated on the page by a single dot. And here is the honest part: **that dot is very often left off**. In ordinary printing and handwriting both are simply written खाना, and the reader is expected to sort it out from context. The nuqta tells you where a sound came from — when somebody bothers to write it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *khānā*; then *khānā dījie*
- the three requests together — *ek chāy dījie*, *ek dūdh dījie*, *khānā dījie*
- *roṭī* and *khānā* — the particular bread and the general word for food
- *khānā* and *khāna* — food and house; then *davākhāna*, the medicine-house

Before you move on

What two jobs does खाना do? (**Food**, and the verb **to eat**.) What is खाना, and where does it come from? (**House, compartment** — Persian خانه, as in *davākhāna*.) Can you always tell them apart on the page? (**No** — the nuqta is often dropped, and context decides.)

37.4 किताब (kitāb) — a book, and the root it is cut from

Not something to eat — something to ask for. Its Arabic root hands you three more words free.

The letters in this word

कि • ता • ब — the first mark is the tricky one.

क with the short ि gives कि (*ki*): the ि is drawn to the **left** of क and sounded **after** it, never *ik*. Then ता, then ब keeping its built-in *a*.

क and त showed you Devanagari's mouth-map: क far back at the soft palate, त at the teeth. Say *ki-tā-b* and feel the tongue travel.

Grammar Lens: feminine, and no ending to prove it

किताब (*kitāb*) = “book,” and it is **feminine** — मेरी किताब.

The second consonant-final noun to turn out feminine, after चाय. Two of this chapter's four disobey any guess their shape allows.

Which is the real lesson: **Hindi gender is information about the word, not the thing and not the spelling.**

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

किताब is **Arabic**, كتاب, come by the Persian road कुर्सी took.

Arabic builds words on **three-consonant roots**, and this one is **k-t-b**, “write.” Slot those three into different patterns and a family appears:

- کتاب *kitāb* — a **book**, the thing written.
- كاتب *kātib* — a **scribe**, the one writing.
- مكتب *maktab* — a **place** of writing: an office, a school.

Learn the root and you have a family, which is how much of Hindi's Perso-Arabic vocabulary is built underneath.

You'll want to know — three books, three registers

Hindi has three words for a book, and they are not synonyms — they are **registers**.

- किताब — Perso-Arabic, the ordinary word. Say this one.
- पुस्तक (*pustak*) — straight out of Sanskrit. Libraries, textbooks, formal writing.
- पोथा (*pothā*) — the inherited descendant of that Sanskrit word. Old, homely, a bit dusty.

You have met this split: कृपया is the *pustak* end of “please,” दीजिए the *kitāb* end.

And that is the chapter — चाय from a Chinese port, दूध named for what was done to it, खाना shadowed by a Persian house, किताब cut from an Arabic root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kitāb*, then *merī kitāb*
- the chapter's four — *merī chāy*, *merā dūdh*, *merā khānā*, *merī kitāb*
- the k-t-b family — *kitāb*, *kātib*, *maktab*
- *kṛpayā* for the sign; *ek chāy dījīe* and *māf kījīe* for the street

Before you move on

Which two words here are feminine, and does their shape say so? (चाय and किताब — no, both end in consonants.) Give the k-t-b family. (*Kitāb*, *kātib*, *maktab*.) Which word for “book” do you say, and which belongs with कृपया? (किताब — पुस्तक is the formal one.)

Chapter 38

Six Words for Where It Hurts

By the end of this chapter: I can name six parts of my body, say that one of them is not well, and tell which three are word-for-word cousins of their English translations — and which one has no traceable ancestry at all.

Say all six body words with the possessive each one demands — मेरा सिर, मेरा हाथ, मेरी आँख, मेरा दाँत, मेरा पैर, मेरा पेट — then say मेरा पेट ठीक नहीं है, and separate the three exact Indo-European cousins from the two words, पेट and रोटी, whose histories genuinely stop.

38.1 आँख (āṁkh) — the eye, which is the same word in English

You have a head and a hand. Here is the part of the face — and this one is not merely *related* to its English translation. It is the same word.

The letters in this word

आँ • ख — and the mark on top is an old friend.

आ is the standalone long *ā*. Over it sits ँ, the **chandrabindu**, the moon-dot, which sends the vowel up through the nose — exactly what it does in हँ. Then ख (*kha*), breathy, with its inherent *a* still attached.

So the word is a nasalised *ā* followed by *kh*: **āṁkh**, humming at the start.

Grammar Lens: feminine, and one you will use daily

आँख (*āṁkh*) = “eye,” and it is **feminine** — मेरी आँख.

Third feminine noun, third consonant ending: चाय, किताब, आँख. If you were still hoping the spelling would rescue you, let this settle it.

And it is worth the effort, because these are the words a doctor asks about. मेरी आँख ठीक नहीं है — “my eye is not well.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

आँख comes from Sanskrit अक्षि (*akṣi*), “eye” — and *akṣi* comes from the root *h₃ekʷ-*, which is one of the securest words in the whole family.

Its descendants:

- Latin **oculus** — inside English **ocular**, **monocle**, **binoculars**.
- Old English **ēage**, which is English **eye** itself.
- Lithuanian **akis**, Armenian **akn**, and Greek **ósse**, the old dual form meaning “the two eyes.”

A caution on the Greek, because the obvious candidate is a trap: **ophthalmós** is *usually* connected here, but its first part has never been explained, and serious opinion treats it as a pre-Greek word. Cite **ósse** and stay honest.

हाथ had to travel a long, battered road from *hasta*. आँख barely travelled at all — *akṣi* to *āṁkh* is a short, clean walk, and at the far end of it an English speaker is saying a version of the same word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *āṁkh*, then *merī āṁkh*
- the three body words you now have — *sir*, *hāth*, *āṁkh*
- *hāmi* and *āṁkh* — the same moon-dot, the same hum
- *akṣi*, *oculus*, *eye* — one root, three languages

Before you move on

Is आँख masculine or feminine? (**Feminine** — *merī ānikh.*) Which Greek word is the safe cousin, and which is the trap? (*ósse* is safe; **ophthalmós** is unexplained.) What does the ँ over the आ do, and where did you first meet it? (**Nasalises** the vowel — on हाँ.)

38.2 दाँत (dāmit) — the tooth, and the gender trap of this chapter

Built like the last word, spelled like the last word, and the opposite gender. This is the pair learners get wrong most often.

The letters in this word

दाँ · त — three known parts and no new letter at all.

द (*da*) takes ा, and the ँ rides above the head-line for the nasal hum — the same **chandrabindu** that turns ह into हाँ, “yes.” Then त (*ta*).

Both द and त are made at the **teeth** — which is the whole point of Devanagari’s mouth-map. The word for *tooth* is spelled with the two consonants your tongue makes *against your teeth*. Say *dāmit* and feel where it happens.

Grammar Lens: the trap

दाँत (*dāmit*) = “tooth,” and it is **masculine** — मेरा दाँत.

Now put the two side by side. आँख and दाँत: same long *ā*, same **chandrabindu**, same single final consonant, both parts of the body, both everyday. आँख is feminine. दाँत is masculine.

There is no rule underneath that. There is no reasoning that gets you from one to the other. This is the pair to hold up whenever you are tempted to guess: मेरी आँख, मेरा दाँत.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

दाँत is Sanskrit दन्त (*danta*), from ***h₃dónts*** — and like *akṣi* this is one of the family’s best-attested words.

- Latin **dēns**, stem *dentis* — English **dentist**, **dental**, **trident** (a “three-tooth”).

- Greek **odoús** — English **odontology**.
- Old English **tōþ**, which is **tooth**.

Two body parts in a row, both plain cousins of their English translations. That is not a coincidence about eyes and teeth; it is what a core inherited vocabulary looks like from the inside.

And the older reading of **h₃dónts** makes it a participle of **h₃ed-**, “to bite” — so a tooth is “**the biting one**,” which is what खाना needs it for. Same move as दूध, “the milked one”: name the thing after what happens.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dāmit*, then *merā dāmit*
- the trap pair, twice — *merī āmikh*, *merā dāmit*; again
- *hāmī*, then *dāmit* — the same moon-dot doing the same job
- *danta*, *dēns*, *odoús*, *tooth* — one word, four languages
- the two “named for the action” words — *dugdha*, the milked; the tooth, the biting one

Before you move on

आँख and दाँत look alike — do they share a gender? (**No** — *merī āmikh*, *merā dāmit*.) Which English words carry the Latin form? (**Dentist**, **dental**, **trident**.) What does the older reading make a tooth? (**The biting one** — from a root meaning “to bite.”)

38.3 पैर (pair) — the foot, and the ancestor it does not have

Down from the head, past the hand, to what carries you. And this word’s obvious ancestor turns out to belong to a different Hindi word.

Grammar Lens: masculine, and the sentence that uses it

पैर (*pair*) = “foot,” and it is **masculine** — मेरा पैर.

The ै is a single mātrā for one vowel, *ai* — not *a* then *i*. One sign, one sound, sitting above the head-line on प.

Now the sentence you would actually say to a doctor, using the नहीं you already have: मेरा पैर ठीक नहीं है — “my foot is not well.” Watch the नहीं sit directly before है, which is where Hindi puts its negation.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Here is the obvious guess, and it is wrong. Sanskrit has पाद (*pāda*), “foot” — long *ā*, famous, the source of English’s borrowed *pada*- words. It looks like it must be the parent of *pair*. It is not.

पाँव (*pānv*), Hindi’s *other* everyday word for foot, is the descendant of पाद. पैर comes from the shorter Sanskrit stem पद् (*pad*-), through Prakrit *paya*, picking up a Middle Indo-Aryan **-ra-** ending on the way.

So Hindi inherited the same body part **twice**, down two different stems of the same word — and both survive, side by side, meaning the same thing.

Further back both are *ped-*, “to walk, to tread”:

- Latin **pēs**, stem *pedis* — **pedal**, **pedestrian**, **pedicure**.
- Greek **πούς**, stem *podós* — **podium**, and the eight of an **octopus**.
- Old English **fōt**, which is **foot**.

Three body words in three lessons, and every one of them is the same word your own language uses. हाथ had to be argued for through a sound change. These three simply *are* the cousins.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pair*, then *merā pair*
- the four body words with their possessives — *merā hāth*, *merī āmikh*, *merā dāmīt*, *merā pair*
- *merā pair thīk nahīm hai* — and hear where the *nahīm* sits

- which Hindi word came from *pāda*, and which from *pad-* (*pāmiv*; *pair*)

Before you move on

Does पैर come from पाद? (No — from पद; पाँव is the *pāda* one.) Which English words carry the Latin and Greek forms? (Pedal, pedestrian; podium, octopus.) Say “my foot is not well,” and say where नहीं goes. (*Merā pair thik nahī hai* — immediately before है.)

38.4 पेट (pet) — the belly, and a trail that genuinely stops

Three clean cousins in a row. This one breaks the run — and the break is worth more than another neat answer.

The letters in this word

पे • ट — one known letter, one known mātṛā, one consonant to feel.

प takes े, the mātṛā that perches on the head-line and turns the built-in *a* into *e* — the second of the two vowel signs you practised on नाम and मेरा.

Then ट: a **retroflex** ṭ, tongue-tip curled back, not the त of दाँत made flat against the teeth. Say *dāṁit*, then *pet*.

Grammar Lens: masculine, and the whole set together

पेट (*pet*) = “stomach, belly,” and it is **masculine** — मेरा पेट.

Now you can answer a doctor, and exactly one of the six takes मेरी: *merā sir*, *merā hāth*, ***merī āṁkh***, *merā dāṁit*, *merā pair*, *merā pet* — feminine company for कुर्सी and किताब.

The sentence, with नहीं in its usual place just before है: मेरा पेट ठीक नहीं है — which, said in India, means what it says and rather more.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पेट goes back to Prakrit पेट्ट (*peṭṭa*) — and there the clean line ends.

The mainstream account treats it as a **Dravidian** word taken into Indo-Aryan; compare reconstructed Dravidian ***poṭṭ-**. Turner’s comparative dictionary does not name Dravidian, but neither does he derive *peṭṭa* from any Sanskrit word: he only remarks that it sits close to Indo-Aryan words for “basket.” That resemblance is a note, not a derivation, and

it is often quoted as one.

So: **the origin of पेट is unsettled**, with Dravidian leading — the honesty रोटी needed, one lesson away from पानी, whose story is exact. A language is made of what people said, and some of that came from neighbours speaking something else.

There is even a fingerprint: the **retroflex** consonants, the ट you just curled your tongue for, are the feature of Indian Indo-Aryan most often credited to long contact with Dravidian.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six — *merā sir, merā hāth, merī āmikh, merā dāmit, merā pair, merā peṭ*
- *merā peṭ thāik nahīmī hai*; then *merī āmikh thāik nahīmī hai*
- every feminine noun you own — *kursī, chāy, kitāb, āmikh*
- the three exact ancestries — *āmikh, dāmit, pair*; then the two unsettled — *peṭ, roṭī*

Before you move on

Where does पेट come from? (**Unsettled** — Prakrit *peṭṭa*, most likely a **Dravidian** loan; the “basket” link is a resemblance.) Of your six body words, which takes मेरी? (आँख.) Which earlier word had the same honest dead end? (रोटी, beside पानी.)

Chapter 39

The People Around You

By the end of this chapter: I can name the friend, the child, the man and the woman around me, I know that दोस्त takes its possessive from the person while आँख never does, and I can choose between औरत and महिला by register.

Say the whole household with every possessive right — मेरा पिता, मेरी माता, मेरा भाई, मेरी बहन, मेरा बच्चा, मेरी बच्ची — then मेरा दोस्त or मेरी दोस्त depending on who the friend is, and say why Arabic ʿawra does not mean “woman” even though औरत does.

39.1 दोस्त (dost) — the friend, who is “the one chosen”

You can name a brother and a sister. Here is the person you picked rather than were given, and the word says exactly that.

The letters in this word

दो · स्त — an ending you have already assembled by hand.

द with ो gives दो. Then स्त — स stripped of its built-in *a* by the **virāma**, fusing with त into one conjunct: the cluster inside नमस्ते, the first conjunct you ever wrote.

So मेरा दोस्त is built entirely from strokes already yours.

Grammar Lens: the noun that leans on who you mean

दोस्त (*dost*) = “friend,” and in the dictionary it is **masculine** — मेरा दोस्त.

But it bends. When the friend is a woman, ordinary modern Hindi says मेरी दोस्त. The word has not changed shape; the **possessive** followed the person. Both are current; neither is a mistake. That is unlike everything so far. आँख is feminine whatever you mean. दोस्त takes its gender from **who the friend is**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

दोस्त is **Persian**, دوست (*dōst*); Old Persian had **dauštā**, an agent noun, “**the one held dear**.”

Its root is **ġews-**, and the old meaning is not “love” but “**to taste, to try, to choose**.” Sanskrit inherited it as जुष् (*juṣ-*). Latin has **gustāre** — English **gusto, disgust** — and English **choose** is the same root.

So a *dōst* is one you have **tried and chosen**; the narrowing to “beloved” happened inside the Indo-Iranian branch alone.

You’ll want to know — why it starts with a d

The consonant at the front of this root came out as **z-** in Avestan and **d-** in **Old Persian**, by a regular sound law across the vocabulary.

Which is why “friend” starts with **د** in Persian and Hindi while its Sanskrit cousin *juṣ-* starts with something else. An initial consonant is a passport stamp: it says which road the word came by.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *merā dost* for a man, *merī dost* for a woman
- the given and the chosen — *merā bhāī*, *merī bahin*, *merā dost*
- *namaste*, then *dost* — one conjunct
- *dōst*, *juṣ-*, *gustāre*, *choose*

Before you move on

How do you say “my friend” about a woman? (मेरी दोस्त — the possessive follows the person.) What did the root behind *dōst* first mean? (**To taste, try, choose**.) Why does Persian say *d-* where Avestan

says z-? (A regular sound law.)

39.2 बच्चा (bacchā) — the child, who is a “yearling”

You have पिता and माता. Here is the third person at that table — and this word finally lets the masculine and feminine forms stand side by side.

Grammar Lens: a pair you can see

बच्चा (bacchā) = “child,” **masculine** — मेरा बच्चा.

Here the lean does real work at last. Swap the final -ा for -ी and you get बच्ची (bacchī), a girl child, **feminine** — मेरी बच्ची.

This is what दरवाज़ा and कुर्सी only hinted at: for *this* class of noun -ā/-ī is not a lean but the machinery, and the word changes with the person. Which is exactly what दोस्त would not do.

You already know how to ask this child’s age: कितने साल के हो? — how many years someone *is of*, rather than how many they *have*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

बच्चा is **Persian**, بچه (bacca) — and the obvious story is wrong.

Persian *bacca* did **not** come from Sanskrit वत्स (vatsa), “calf, young one.”

The two are **sisters**: one Indo-Iranian word inherited down two separate branches. Centuries later the Persian one was borrowed into Hindi — which had *already* inherited the Sanskrit one as बछड़ा (bachṛā), “calf.” So Hindi holds both, the same ancient word by two roads — the pattern दरवाज़ा and द्वार showed you, running again, and the same Persian relay that brought दोस्त.

Behind both stands *wet-*, “year.” Latin *vetus*, “old,” is from it — English **veteran** — and so are Latin *vitulus*, “calf,” and English **wether**, a yearling sheep.

A child, at the root, is a **yearling**. पिता and माता are named by relationship; बच्चा is named by age.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bacchā* and *bacchī*; then *merā bacchā*, *merī bacchī*

- the family — *merā pitā, merī mātā, merā bacchā*
- the two roads — *bacchā* from Persian, *bachṛā* inherited; one word
- *vetus, vitulus, wether* — and the meaning under all of them (year)

Before you move on

What is the feminine of बच्चा, and how does the possessive move? (बच्ची — *merā bacchā, merī bacchī*.) Is Persian *bacca* descended from Sanskrit *vatsa*? (**No** — they are **sisters**; Hindi’s inherited cousin is बछड़ा.) What does the root mean? (**Year** — a child is a yearling.)

39.3 आदमी (*ādmī*) — the man, and the lean breaking backwards

The child has grown up. And this word does what none so far has — it ends in -ी and is masculine anyway.

Grammar Lens: the lean breaks the other way

आदमी (*ādmī*) = “**man, person**,” and it is **masculine**. Say एक आदमी — it is also the ordinary word for “person” in general, and stays masculine doing that. Ask कितने साल के हो? of him and you are asking how many years he *is of*, the way Hindi counts age.

A warning before you reach for the possessive: मेरा आदमी is real Hindi but means what English’s *my man* means. Keep एक आदमी.

The gender still shows the instant anything agrees with the noun. Put it beside कुर्सी: both end in long -ी, one is feminine, one masculine, and no reasoning takes you from the ending to the answer. Beside बच्चा / बच्ची, where the ending *does* carry the gender, the contrast is sharper.

So the lean has failed in **both** directions: चाय and किताब feminine with no -ी, आदमी masculine with one.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

आदमी is **Arabic**, آدمي (*ādamī*), and it came the Persian way — the road of कुर्सी and किताब.

Now the ending. That -ī is not Hindi at all. It is the **Arabic ending** meaning “**belonging to, of the kind of**.” Attach it to آدم (*Ādam*)

and you get “**of Adam.**” A human being, in this word, is one of Adam’s. آدم is Hebrew *ʿādām*, and here care is needed. You have probably heard that *ʿādām* comes from *ʿadāmāh*, “ground” — man made of earth. Genesis sets the two side by side and means you to notice: a **deliberate pun**, and a famous one.

It is not the etymology. The prevailing view links the root ʿ-d-m to **redness** — behind Hebrew *ʿadōm*, “red,” and **Edom**. Beyond that, unsettled.

Worth keeping: **a wordplay a text makes on purpose is not where a word came from.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ādmī*, then *ek ādmī*
- *kursī* feminine, *ādmī* masculine; then *merī kursī*, and stop
- the lean, and both ways it fails — *chāy*, *kitāb*, *ādmī*
- what the -ī on *ādmī* means

Before you move on

कुर्सी and आदमी end alike — same gender? (**No.**) What is the -ī of *ādmī* doing? (**Arabic “belonging to”** — “of Adam.”) Is *ʿādām* from the word for ground? (**No** — Genesis is making a deliberate pun; the root is usually connected to **redness**.)

39.4 औरत (aurat) — the word for “woman,” and which one to use

The last word of the chapter, and the one where Hindi hands you a choice rather than a word.

Grammar Lens: the pair, and the family complete

औरत (*aurat*) = “**woman**,” and it is **feminine**. Say एक औरत — and for the reason एक आदमी was the safe phrase, leave मेरी औरत alone: it means

my woman, a wife. औ is one vowel letter, *au*, standing alone. Consonant ending, feminine — as चाय, किताब and आँख were. Beside it आदमी: -ी ending, masculine. Neither adult's gender is reachable from spelling. Where you *can* hear the agreement is on the child: मेरा बच्चा, मेरी बच्ची, the yearling who takes the ending seriously. The family: पिता, माता, भाई, बहन, बच्चा, आदमी, औरत — and the chosen one, दोस्त.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

औरत is **Arabic**, عورة (*ʿawra*), on the three-consonant root **ʿ-w-r** — built the way **k-t-b** built किताब — whose senses run to *a weak point, a gap in a defence, something left uncovered*.

Then the fact that changes what you do with all that: **Arabic ʿawra does not mean “woman.”** That sense is a **Persian** development. Persian moved the noun to mean a woman or a wife and handed *that* to Hindi and Urdu, on record from around 1420 — the same Persian relay that carried दोस्त.

So the harsh root sense is not a claim Arabic makes about women. It is the earlier life of a word another language repurposed.

You'll want to know — three words, and which to say

Three words, and the choice is **register**, exactly as for किताब / पुस्तक / पोथा.

- औरत — Perso-Arabic, plain and everyday. Common in speech; some speakers avoid it formally, partly because of the origin above.
- महिला (*mahilā*) — a Sanskrit borrowing, the **respectful, public** word: signs, announcements, official prose. Its Sanskrit origin is **uncertain**; one serious proposal traces it to Dravidian.
- स्त्री (*strī*) — Sanskrit, older and literary. Secure back to Indo-Iranian, no further.

महिला where you would write, औरत where you would talk.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ek aurat*, then *ek ādmī* — neither ending gives its gender away
- *merā pitā*, *merī mātā*, *merā bhāī*, *merī bahīn*, *merā bacchā*, *merī bacchī*
- *merā dost*, then *merī dost*
- every feminine noun you own — *kursī*, *chāy*, *kitāb*, *ānīkh*, *bacchī*

Before you move on

Does Arabic عورة mean “woman”? (**No** — that sense is **Persian**.) Which goes on a public sign, which in conversation? (महिला written; औरत spoken.) Your family, minding every possessive? (*Merā pitā*, *merī mātā*, *merā bhāī*, *merī bahīn*, *merā bacchā*.)

Devanagari — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a”**: क = ka, न = na, म = ma.
2. **A vowel sign (*mātrā*) changes that vowel**: ा = ā (का kā), ि = i (written before, read after), े = e (के ke), and ि ु ू ै ौ ौ for ī, u, ū, ai, o, au.
3. **A *halant* (ँ) removes the built-in vowel**: क् = bare k. A vowel-less consonant leans onto the next as a **conjunct**: स् + त → स्त (st), न् + य → न्य (ny).

Independent vowels (word-initial)

अ a · आ ā · इ i · ई ī · उ u · ऊ ū · ए e · ऐ ai · ओ o · औ au.

Worth flagging

- **Aspiration** distinguishes letters: क k / ख kh, त t / थ th, द d / ध dh — the “h” is a real puff.
- **Retroflex** (ट ढ ण) vs. **dental** (त द न): tongue curled back vs. on the teeth.
- **Nukta** (a dot below) marks Perso-Arabic/English sounds: ज़ z, फ़ f, क़ q.

The two vocabularies

Many everyday ideas have two Hindi words — a **Sanskrit** one, often formal (*dhanyavād, namaste*), and a **Perso-Arabic** one, often everyday (*shukriyā, alvidā*). The lessons trace which is which.